

Human Acts



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF HAN KANG

Han Kang was born in Gwangju, South Korea, less than two decades after the end of the Korean War (and just 10 years before the events of the novel). Han's father, Han Seung-won, was a celebrated novelist in the 1950s and 1960s who worked as a creative writing teacher in Gwangju before moving with his family to Seoul in late 1979. It was during Han's high school and college years in Seoul that she started to follow in her father's footsteps, writing poetry and her debut novel, *A Love of Yeosu* (1995). After achieving widespread popularity in Korea, Han rose to international fame with her novel *The Vegetarian*, written in 2007 and translated to English in 2016, when it won the Man Booker prize. Han, who also works as a musician, sculptor, and non-fiction essayist, currently lives and teaches writing in Seoul.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In 1979, South Korean military dictator Park Chung-hee was assassinated. A few months later, on May 17, 1980, Park's mentee Chun Doo-hwan seized power in a military coup, declaring martial law. In the days before and after this coup, students at Chonnam National University in Gwangju staged city-wide, non-violent protests against Doo-hwan's reign (known collectively as "the Gwangju uprising," or the "May 18 democratic uprising"). Chun Doo-hwan's crackdown on these protests was swift and brutal, as two army battalions arrived on planes and tanks to silence the activists. Hundreds of civilians were killed, thousands more were injured, and the very phrase "5:18 Democratic Uprising" was criminalized. Han's novel focuses on these weeks in May 1980 when young people rose up and were massacred, but it also deals with the reverberations of the 5:18 protests throughout history. In 2013, when Han began to write *Human Acts*, South Korea was being forced to once again grapple with the implications of the Gwangju uprising, as Park Chung-hee's daughter Park Geun-hye assumed the presidency (until she was impeached in 2017).

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Han frequently cites modernist Korean poets Lim-Chul Woo and Yi Sang as stylistic influences. She also sees Russian novelist Fyodor Dostoevsky as an important inspiration, perhaps because Dostoevsky, like Han, demonstrates a willingness to bring readers into his characters' sense of grief and dislocation. Having been raised by a prominent author, however, Han finds herself consistently drawn to new plots and forms: "it isn't easy for me to namecheck favorite writers," she

explains, "because they always change." The structure of *Human Acts*, which requires multiple different narrators, narration from beyond the grave, and the use of the second-person perspective, is rooted in some important modernist and post-modernist techniques. The shift in narration is a device perhaps most frequently associated with William Faulkner (in books like *As I Lay Dying* and *Absalom, Absalom*), while the use of the second-person perspective is a favorite narrative technique of Italian writer Italo Calvino.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Human Acts
- **When Written:** 2013–2016
- **Where Written:** Seoul, South Korea
- **When Published:** 2016
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Gwangju, South Korea
- **Climax:** Dong-ho, only in middle school, is killed by South Korean soldiers while trying to peacefully surrender.
- **Antagonist:** President Chun Doo-hwan and his military government
- **Point of View:** Various

EXTRA CREDIT

Literary Lineage. In addition to her father Han Seung-won, Han Kang's brother Han Dong-rim has also had a successful career as a writer. And in living up to her father's literary legacy, Han has also snagged many of the same prizes her father won decades earlier, including the prestigious Yin Sang and Kim Tong-ni literary awards.

It's All Greek to Me. In *Human Acts*, Han is fascinated and horrified by the powers of censorship and forced silence—but interestingly, Han's most recent novel *Greek Lessons*, published in 2023, follows a woman whose silence originates from within. When the protagonist mysteriously loses her ability to speak, she decides to study ancient Greek, hoping that the rarely spoken language will teach her to find meaning in silence.



PLOT SUMMARY

It's May 1980, and Dong-ho is a middle-schooler living in Gwangju, a city on the southern tip of South Korea. Almost by accident, Dong-ho has become involved in the student protests against military dictator Chun Doo-hwan. Alongside fellow

activists Eun-sook, Seon-ju, and Jin-su, Dong-ho helps clean and classify the bodies murdered by state soldiers. Dong-ho takes his job seriously, laying the Taegukgi over the dead and lighting **candles** to honor the corpses. Though most of the protestors are students, Dong-ho is the youngest of all, and his work worries both his mother and his middle brother.

A few days ago, Dong-ho watched as soldiers shot down his best friend, Jeong-dae, in the middle of a mass protest. Last week, Jeong-dae's sister Jeong-mi (long the object of Dong-ho's affections) disappeared. Dong-ho blames himself for both of these losses, obsessing over what happens to people's "fluttering" souls when they die. Tonight, Chun Doo-hwan's soldiers are coming back into Gwangju, and everyone knows there will be carnage. Dong-ho's mother pleads with him to leave the Provincial Office where he works, but Dong-ho refuses, promising that he will be home by dinner.

The story shifts perspective, and now Jeong-dae, recently murdered, is narrating from beyond the grave. To his horror, Jeong-dae's body has been taken to a clearing, where it is thrown at the bottom of a pile of corpses. Jeong-dae senses that his sister Jeong-mi has also been killed, and he longs to punish the soldiers who have murdered her. Though there are other souls in this clearing, Jeong-dae cannot figure out how to communicate with any of them. His only hope is to find Dong-ho and watch over his still-living friend.

After a few days, while his body rots and swells and turns black, Jeong-dae learns that the soldiers have come to burn the pile of corpses. He is initially relieved, believing that being rid of his body will allow his soul to roam Gwangju more freely. But as his body goes up in smoke, Jeong-dae realizes with despair that Dong-ho, too, has been murdered.

Five years later, Eun-sook is working in a book publisher's office. While working on the company's latest book, a Korean translation of some protest plays, Eun-sook is called into the police station for her involvement in the piece. While at the station, the interrogator slaps Eun-sook seven times. For the next week, Eun-sook resolves to forget one slap each day. Though years have passed, Eun-sook is still haunted by her memories of the Gwangju massacre, so she rarely leaves her house other than to go to work.

At the end of the week, Eun-sook brings the book to the censor's office. She is horrified to see that the censors have blotted out entire pages (even though usually they only cross out a few words). But the play's producer, Mr. Seo, is firm that the show will go on, honoring the victims of Gwangju even though Chun Doo-hwan's government is still in power. When Eun-sook attends the premiere, she sees the actors silently mouthing the censored words. One young actor, wearing **trackpants**, reminds her of Dong-ho.

Five more years pass, and an unnamed narrator reflects on the months that he was imprisoned for protesting in Gwangju.

While in prison, the narrator was forced to share all of his meals with the silent, effeminate Jin-su. Both men are subjected to many forms of torture, including one that involves mutilating their hands with a **pen**. The narrator contrasts the experience of feeling like "raw meat" in prison with the memories of protests, when he felt that he and the crowd of activists shared "the sublime enormity of a single heart." Over the course of his time in prison, the narrator befriends Jin-su and a younger boy named Yeong-chae. Yeong-chae leads the prisoners in several small acts of protests, though he also bursts into tears whenever he thinks of his favorite sweet treats. In his innocence and courage, Yeong-chae reminds both the narrator and Jin-su of Dong-ho.

Now, Yeong-chae has been institutionalized and Jin-su has killed himself. The narrator, too, has struggled with alcoholism and depression, and he lashes out at the professor (Yoon) who is interviewing him about the Gwangju Uprising. The narrator believes that the only thing all humans have in common is their ability to be cruel to each other, like "ravening beast[s]."

In 2002, Seon-ju is working as an environmental activist. For the most part, she is secretive about her role in the Gwangju protests, ignoring Yoon's requests for an interview. But when Seon-ju learns that her old friend, labor activist Seong-hee, has fallen gravely ill, she feels newly motivated to tell her story.

As Seon-ju tries to work up the nerve to visit Seong-hee in the hospital, she is haunted by regret, her narration interrupted by a series of confused, half-remembered vignettes (which the novel calls "Up Risings"). Finally, Seon-ju reveals the truth of what happened to her in the years after Gwangju: she was sexually assaulted, brutalized to the point that she can no longer have children or stand any form of sexual intimacy. Seon-ju blames herself for Dong-ho's death, wishing she had sent him home instead of merely sharing gimhap with him. But Dong-ho's memory also gives Seon-ju strength, and she resolves to keep going in tribute to the murdered young boy.

Eight years later, Dong-ho's mother still sometimes hallucinates Dong-ho on the streets of Gwangju. She replays the day of her son's death, wondering if she could have done more to bring him home and resenting the other young activists for refusing to let her grab Dong-ho before the killing began. Dong-ho's mother also laments renting out the annex of their family hanok to Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi, though she knows Dong-ho's friendship with Jeong-dae was a highlight of his life.

Dong-ho's older brother has moved away, but usually when he visits, he and the middle brother fight, blaming each other for Dong-ho's death. Meanwhile, Dong-ho's mother gets to know other grieving parents, and they join together to protest, despite arrests and injuries. After Dong-ho's father dies, however, Dong-ho's mother loses steam. Now, all she can do is remember, thinking back to the poems Dong-ho used to create. In 2013, the writer—a stand-in for author Han Kang herself—is

beginning to write a book about the Gwangju protests, told from the perspective of Dong-ho and those who loved him. The writer has a personal connection to the uprising: her family used to live in the hanok that they then sold to Dong-ho's parents. Though the writer moved to Seoul a few months before the protests began, the writer's father stayed in touch with many friends in Gwangju.

The more the writer studies the Gwangju protests, visiting the 5:18 Research Institute and the house where she used to live, the more she becomes obsessed with Dong-ho and the pain he suffered. Before she leaves Gwangju, the writer visits Dong-ho's grave, lighting a candle to pay her respects.



CHARACTERS

Dong-ho – Dong-ho, the central character in *Human Acts*, is a middle schooler in Gwangju at the time of the 5:18 uprising. After Dong-ho's best friend Jeong-dae is killed, Dong-ho begins volunteering at the Provincial Office alongside Eun-sook, Seon-ju, and Jin-su, helping to honor and classify the corpses of murdered protestors. Dong-ho's remarkable bravery and ability to keep calm under pressure is contrasted by some of his more youthful traits: the **trackpants** that are too big for him, the delight he takes in sponge cakes and gimbap, and the innocent crush he has on Jeong-mi. When Dong-ho, carried away by the sentiment of the crowd, resolves to stay in the Provincial Office even as Chun Doo-hwan's soldiers return, he does not seem to realize that he is condemning himself to an almost certain death. Years after his death, Eun-sook is haunted by his face the last time she saw him, as she could tell he "wanted to live." After Dong-ho's death, nearly every other character in the novel (from Dong-ho's mother to his still-vengeful middle brother to silent Jin-su) blames themselves for his death. But in telling his story, each character also preserves Dong-ho's memory, allowing him to live beyond the horrific violence that killed him.

The Writer – The writer, closely based on *Human Acts* author Han Kang herself, is a novelist. The writer was born in Gwangju, living in a hanok there until she was nine. When the writer's father moved the family to Seoul, Dong-ho's family bought the house and moved in. As a little girl, the writer saw herself in parallel to Dong-ho, hearing snippets of conversation about this bright, creative young boy who had been shot down in the Gwangju riots. Now, as an adult, the writer returns to Gwangju, determined to capture Dong-ho's story (and to share the larger narrative of the 5:18 uprising with the world). The writer ends the narrative by traveling to Dong-ho's grave, lighting a **candle** to honor this young boy she never knew. As the candle "flutter[s]" in the wind, the writer imagines that she feels a connection to Dong-ho's soul, kept alive by her words of memory and testimony.

Jeong-dae – Jeong-dae is Jeong-mi's little brother and Dong-ho's best friend. Like Dong-ho, Jeong-dae is small for his age, and the novel often emphasizes that the **trackpants** he always wears are far too big for him. Before the outbreak of the Gwangju protests, Jeong-dae is a troublemaker, taking odd jobs behind his sister's back and playing pranks on his schoolmates. He and Dong-ho are also constantly competing in badminton, cracking each other up as they play. Jeong-dae is killed early in the Gwangju violence, and he narrates the rest of the 5:18 uprising from beyond the grave, as his soul looks with disgust on his decomposing body. Dong-ho, who was present when Jeong-dae was shot, to some extent holds himself responsible for his friend's death—and so much of Dong-ho's volunteer work at the Provincial Office is motivated by his memories of his beloved Jeong-dae.

Jeong-mi – Jeong-mi is Jeong-dae's sister. She and her brother rent out the annex in Dong-ho's hanok. Jeong-mi is remarkably stubborn, bossing her brother around and pushing herself to her limits in factory work to fund his education. She is also pretty—Dong-ho harbors a secret crush on her—and prone to jokes, often delighting in Jeong-dae's goofiest pranks. Though Jeong-mi has had to sacrifice her own education in order to finance her brother's schooling, she dreams of being a doctor, an impossibility that still haunts her old friend Seon-ju many years after Jeong-mi's death. Jeong-mi disappears in the early weeks of the Gwangju uprising. Years later, Dong-ho's mother finds conclusive evidence that Jeong-mi was killed in the first round of state violence.

Eun-sook – Eun-sook is a high-school volunteer at the Gwangju Provincial Office during the time of the 5:18 uprising. She is the only one of the characters who leaves the office the night state soldiers return, escaping to a nearby hospital to wait out the carnage. In the aftermath, she feels guilt about leaving and about not doing anything to protect Dong-ho. Years later, the once-cheerful Eun-sook is a private, quiet young woman, with no friends or lovers. She spends all her time at home or working at a publishing house, reporting to a timid publisher and collaborating with a controversial translator. Still, Eun-sook continues to resist in quieter ways, helping to produce a slate of potentially seditious plays even when she faces interrogation and violence for doing so.

Jin-su – Jin-su is the unspoken leader of the student organizers during the 5:18 uprising. He is also a boss, mentor, and support system for Dong-ho, Eun-sook, and Seon-ju. Jin-su advises Dong-ho to leave the Provincial Office when Chun Doo-hwan's soldiers return to Gwangju. When Dong-ho refuses, Jin-su tells him to surrender. Still, Jin-su blames himself for Dong-ho's death, a loss that haunts him long into adulthood. After being imprisoned and tortured alongside an unnamed narrator and the young Yeong-chae, Jin-su loses faith completely, slipping into a life of depression and alcoholism. After Yeong-chae is institutionalized for a violent outburst, Jin-su wonders what

the point of existence is; “it was only when we were shattered,” he reflects, “that we proved we had souls.” Unable to bear the brutality that he and his closest friends have been subjected to, Jin-su kills himself in 1990, 10 years after the uprising.

The Narrator – The unnamed narrator is one of the oldest student protestors working at the Provincial Office during the 5:18 uprising. The narrator is imprisoned alongside Jin-su and Yeong-chae and forced to share her meager portions of food with Jin-su. Though the narrator initially resents Jin-su because of their small rations, the two men bond after they are released and find themselves unable to shake their memories of brutal torture. After Yeong-chae is institutionalized and Jin-su kills himself, the professor Yoon tries to interview the narrator—but though the narrator shares his testimony, he lashes out, unable to contemplate why Jin-su died but he is still alive. Throughout his recollections of his time in prison, the narrator considers how torture—specifically the pain inflicted on him with a fancy **pen**—is used to reduce human beings into nothing more than “filthy stinking bodies,” devoid of pride or “conscience.” At the same time, he marvels at the way crowds of protestors can find strength and clarity in their shared experiences—insight that not one of them could achieve on their own.

Yeong-chae – Yeong-chae is the youngest person imprisoned alongside Jin-su and the unnamed narrator. In his youth and bravery, Yeong-chae reminds Jin-su (often painfully) of Dong-ho. Yeong-chae tends to waver between adult strength and childlike innocence: he might lead the other prisoners in a beautiful, forbidden version of the national anthem, risking death, only to collapse into tears moments later at the mention of his favorite sweet foods (Fanta and sponge cake). Ten years after they were all jailed and tortured together, Jin-su reveals to the narrator that Yeong-chae has gone mad, ending up institutionalized after a violent outbreak.

Seon-ju – Seon-ju is one of the students who worked in the Provincial Office, dealing with the corpses left by the Gwangju massacre and protesting against Chun Doo-hwan. Unlike most of the other protestors, Seon-ju’s entire life has been defined by various forms of activism. Before the Gwangju protests, Seon-ju worked alongside her close friend Seong-hee, organizing for labor rights. After the protests, Seon-ju goes to work at an environmental organization, helping to advocate against the use of radioactive substances. Whenever she is jailed for these various forms of resistance, Seon-ju is brutalized and sexually assaulted, leaving her unable to have children or even conceive of intimacy with men. When Yoon asks to interview Seon-ju for his oral history, she is initially reluctant. But memories of the fearless Seong-hee, now in the hospital, eventually encourage her to speak up.

Seong-hee – Seong-hee is a prominent labor activist in the 1970s, as well as a close friend (and mentor) to Seon-ju. By the 1990s, Seong-hee has become a hero to progressive South Koreans like Park Yeong-ho, largely because of her radical

organizing tactics (which include large-scale sit-ins and having young women strip naked in protest). Seong-hee frequently pushes Seon-ju to tell the story of her experience in the Gwangju uprisings, and Seon-ju feels that Seong-hee is judging her. By the end of Seon-ju’s narrative, Seong-hee and Seon-ju are estranged, and Seong-hee is in the hospital, aware that death is likely on the horizon.

Dong-ho’s Mother – Dong-ho’s mother is the mother of the older brother, the middle brother, and Dong-ho. She is also married to (and then eventually widowed by) Dong-ho’s father. Decades after Dong-ho’s death, Dong-ho’s mother still shapes her days around her beloved son, following a little boy through the streets of Gwangju simply because his **trackpants** remind her of her son. But though her grief is sometimes paralyzing, it is also energizing: toward the end of Chun Doo-hwan’s tenure, Dong-ho’s mother joins forces with other bereaved parents to protest, fighting back even when she is taken to jail or tear-gassed. Dong-ho’s mother is also committed to remembering her son beyond his involvement in the uprising—she also remembers him as a young boy, writing short poems and playing in the flowers.

The Older Brother – The older brother is the eldest child of Dong-ho’s father and Dong-ho’s mother; he is a few years older than the middle brother, and 11 years older than Dong-ho. The older brother is very intelligent and cheerful, and though he moves to Seoul for work, he continues to visit Dong-ho’s mother regularly into her old age. The older brother was very attached to Dong-ho in his infancy, and he resents the middle brother for not doing more to protect Dong-ho that day at the Provincial Office.

The Middle Brother – The middle brother is the second child of Dong-ho’s father and Dong-ho’s mother. He is not as successful as his older brother, who moves to Seoul, and he struggles with survivor’s guilt following Dong-ho’s death. Though the middle brother remains in Gwangju his entire life, working at a “cram school” (a private tutoring company), he is reluctant to visit home. The older brother blames the middle brother for Dong-ho’s death, believing that he could have done more to bring Dong-ho home from the Provincial Office on that fateful night. Dong-ho’s mother notes that the middle brother has internalized this sense of guilt: he is constantly angry and agitated. And even decades later, the middle brother cannot let go of his wish for revenge on the soldiers who killed Dong-ho.

Dong-ho’s Father – Dong-ho’s father is married to Dong-ho’s mother, and he is a parent to the older brother, the middle brother, and Dong-ho himself. The novel generally suggests that Dong-ho’s father is sweet and reserved, not getting swept into either grief or protest to the same extent that his wife does. Dong-ho’s father falls sick and dies in the late 1990s, making his wife a widow.

President Chun Doo-hwan – President Chun Doo-hwan ruled

South Korea as a military dictator from the fall of 1980 to the winter of 1988. After being primed for office by his equally dictatorial predecessor, Park Chung-hee, Chun seized power in a military coup on May 17, 1980, prompting the 5:18 uprising in Gwangju. Chun's crackdown on the uprising was brutal, with hundreds of civilians (many of them young people) murdered and thousands more left injured and traumatized. Throughout the novel, many of the characters reflect on the gap between Chun's sleek appearance and the brutality he and his government are capable of.

The Interrogator – The interrogator works at Eun-sook's local police station. When he learns that Eun-sook has worked with the wanted translator to publish a controversial play in Korean, he slaps her seven times, startling her with his brutality. For a week, Eun-sook remains haunted by these slaps; she especially struggles with the fact that the interrogator looks “utterly ordinary”; “had they met on the street,” Eun-sook thinks, “she would have taken him for some run-of-the-mill company manager.”

The Translator – The translator is a mild-mannered man who helps translate the controversial play Eun-sook is working on into Korean. The translator is wanted by South Korean authorities in Chun Doo-hwan's regime, but he has thus far managed to escape detection. The whole time Eun-sook is meeting with the translator, she is struck by how polite and deferential he is to her, even though he is many years her senior.

The Publisher – The publisher is Eun-sook's boss at the publishing house. He is depicted as a somewhat cowardly man, as he lets Eun-sook take the blame—and the violence that comes with it—for working with the criminalized translator. But by the end of Eun-sook's narrative, the publisher is working to overcome his fear, printing the plays Mr. Seo wants to produce even though he knows it will mean trouble.

Mr. Seo – Mr. Seo is the producer of the controversial play Eun-sook is trying to get published. Though he shares Eun-sook's despair at the state's censorship of the play—entire pages have been blotted out with **ink-rollers**—he works with the publisher to circumvent the government's prohibition. Eventually, Mr. Seo stages the play, having the actors mouth the blotted-out lines rather than say them out loud. This seditious act could potentially mean imprisonment or torture for Mr. Seo, but Eun-sook finds this version of the play especially galvanizing and beautiful.

The Professor/Yoon – The professor, later revealed to be named Yoon, is working on an oral history of the Gwangju uprising (what he calls a “psychological autopsy”). The professor is slowly interviewing all the surviving student protestors, though he often meets resistance from those most traumatized, like Seon-ju. Though some survivors decide that bearing “witness” to the 5:18 massacre should be the priority,

others—specifically the narrator—continue to distrust the professor even after they share testimony with him.

Park Yeong-ho – Park Yeong-ho is Seon-ju's boss at the activist environmental organization where she now works. Yeong-ho is younger than Seon-ju, and he looks up to her because he knows she used to organize and protest with famed labor activist Seong-hee. Yeong-ho is the only one of Seon-ju's colleagues with whom she has any real relationship, and he often sweetly teases her about her impeccable work ethic.

Jeong-dae's Father – Jeong-dae's father, also father to Jeong-mi, arrives in Gwangju soon after he hears the news that his children have disappeared. Though it is evident to everyone that Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi have been killed, Jeong-dae's father refuses to accept this, searching for them during the days and drinking to excess at night. Dong-ho's mother sees Jeong-dae's father as a kind of mirror to herself: though both are destroyed by their grief for their murdered children, only Dong-ho's mother is able to accept reality and use her grief as a tool of change.

The Writer's Father – The writer's father is a creative writing teacher in Gwangju. Though he moves the writer and the rest of her family to Seoul just a few months before the Gwangju uprising, the writer's father stays in touch with old friends in his former city, getting news about the 5:18 protests and the horrors that followed. The writer's father is likely based on Han Kang's real father, the celebrated South Korean author Han Seung-won.

TERMS

Gimbap – Gimbap (sometimes anglicized as kimbab) is a popular Korean snack. Usually consisting of rice, carrots, pickled radish, cucumber, and tuna or ham, gimbap are rolled in seaweed to form sushi-shaped bites. Because of their size and seaweed wrappers, gimbap are good on the go, which perhaps explains why they are such a popular snack in the throes of the Gwangju protests.

Hanok – The word hanok refers to a traditional Korean architectural style. Hanoks in Gwangju were often L-shaped, with a central courtyard and a small annex. In the novel, **Dong-ho's** family buys a hanok from **the writer's** family, moving in and renting out the annex to **Jeong-mi** and **Jeong-dae**. Later in life, the writer laments that the peaceful stone hanok of her childhood has been torn down, replaced by more modern development.

Provincial Office – The Old Jeonnam Provincial Office (sometimes also known as the South Jeolla Provincial Office) was the seat of the Gwangju municipal government. In the 1980 uprising, the Provincial Office became the center of student-led protests. It is fitting, then, that in *Human Acts*, the Provincial Office is the place where **Dong-ho** first meets fellow

activists **Jin-su**, **Eun-sook**, and **Seon-ju**.

Taegukgi – Since 1948, the Taegukgi (also anglicized as the Taegeuk) has been the national flag of South Korea. The flag's white background represents the land South Korea sits on, while the blue and red circle at the center is meant to symbolize the Korean people. The four sets of black lines, one in each corner, represent the nation's government. In the novel, the Taegukgi is used in funerals for murdered protestors, a ritual that confuses **Dong-ho**, as it was the government of the nation the flags represent that killed the protestors.

5:18 – Because **Chun Doo-hwan**'s military government officially came to power on May 17, 1980, the anti-Chun Doo-hwan protests in Gwangju were often collectively known as the May 18 uprising. Under Chun Doo-hwan's reign, the phrase "5:18" was forbidden in South Korea, as it was seen as seditious. In more recent years, however, May 18 has become a National Day of Remembrance for those lost in the Gwangju massacre. Moreover, as **the writer** sees when she returns home to Gwangju, there are now a number of buildings dedicated to studying this history, like the 5:18 Research Institute.

"clear edges." For better or for worse, *Human Acts* suggests, crowds always erase individuality.

On the level of plot, this loss of self is a great tragedy, as crowds of soldiers murder crowds of protestors (including Jeong-dae, his sister Jeong-mi, and the novel's young protagonist Dong-ho). But on a structural level, the novel demonstrates that connection and commitment to a shared cause can preserve an individual even beyond the bounds of their physical life. Each chapter in the narrative, spanning from 1980 to 2013, pauses to honor Dong-ho, giving details about the way he spoke and dressed and laughed. Therefore, even as Dong-ho is killed in part because he loses himself in the swell of a crowd, his figurative inclusion in a crowd of activists, artists, and protestors who tell his story throughout *Human Acts*, determined to give his life and death meaning, ultimately preserves and extends his memory.



BODIES AND VULNERABILITY

Han Kang's 2014 novel *Human Acts*, which follows a group of protestors in the years after the 1980 Gwangju uprising, is full of descriptions of bodies in distress. Dong-ho, the novel's murdered protagonist, spends his middle-school years cleaning and categorizing corpses, noting how death swells toes and whitens faces. Seon-ju, who spends her life moving from activist group to the next, can comprehend complex labor and environmental issues—but she can never wrap her head around the way that soldiers brutalized young women's "naked bodies," which she once believed to be "almost sacred." An unnamed narrator, tortured in prison for months, reflects that the soldiers' goal is to reduce him to "raw meat," stealing his sense of personhood and replacing it with the sense that he is only a "filthy, stinking body." And Jeong-dae, a young activist whose ghost narrates a section of the novel, feels similarly ashamed of his corporeal form, now simply one more body at the bottom of a pile.

But as Jeong-dae learns when he is reduced to nothing but a flitting soul, even in death, one cannot escape their own flesh and blood. For nearly all of the characters in *Human Acts*, bodies are a source not only of pain but of vulnerability: the imprisoned narrator makes false confessions just to make the torture stop, while book publisher Eun-sook, determined to publish controversial texts, loses her will after being slapped seven times in a row. But even as the novel illustrates the vulnerability of the body, it also suggests that bodily experiences are unavoidable and unignorable. By emphasizing bodily vulnerability, *Human Acts* highlights the fragility of life. For the protestors in Han's novel, pain, physical humiliation, and death are always just around the corner. In light of this, then, it becomes critically important to *choose* to regard all life with dignity and respect. Conversely, failing to do so, as the book's depictions of violence and trauma repeatedly show, devalues life, reducing characters to mere "raw meat" rather



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



HUMAN CONNECTION

Human Acts, Han Kang's 2014 novel about the 1980 Gwangju uprising, is filled with scenes depicting crowds. Some depict protestors chanting and singing in unison, refusing to bend to the tyranny of then-president Chun Doo-hwan. In others, crowds of soldiers rush to fire their guns, encouraging one another to kill more innocents. Elsewhere, the novel depicts crowds of corpses piled together for group funerals. In each case, the narrative suggests that individual people transform in crowds, becoming capable of acts of bravery or brutality they could never achieve on their own. One such individual is an unnamed narrator, imprisoned alongside Gwangju activist Jin-su, who spends his time in jail reflecting on the bravery he felt in a crowd. "I remember feeling that it was alright to die," the narrator thinks, because he felt "the blood of a hundred thousand hearts surging together [...] the sublime enormity of a single heart, pushing blood into my own." Similarly, Jeong-dae, who speaks in the novel only as a ghost, experiences a more tragic version of this loss of self: thrown at the bottom of a pile of dead bodies, he muses that he has "crumbled into ambiguity," losing his own

than people with individual aspirations, quirks, and strengths.



LANGUAGE, MEMORY, AND POWER

Throughout *Human Acts*, Han Kang's novel about the 1980 Gwangju uprising, language emerges as a powerful tool of resistance and memory. A

professor named Yoon, determined to publish a true account of the harrowing protests, insists that only through oral history can survivors "bear witness" to the pain they experienced in the past. Theatrical producer Mr. Seo skirts government restrictions, causing a mass of protest poems to rain down on audience members even after the state forbids the text of his play. And the character of the writer—a stand-in for Han Kang herself—uses language to remember the dead protestors the state would rather erase from history. "Write your book," one interviewee tells her, "so that no one will ever be able to desecrate my brother's memory ever again." In other words, language can heal, preserve, and correct injustice.

It follows, therefore, that throughout the novel, the South Korean government sees squashing language as an important imperative. State-sponsored soldiers beat and brutalize students and young activists merely for the text on their fliers. Government censors block whole pages of text, using **ink rollers** to erase any idea they consider seditious. When activist Jin-su is tortured (alongside young Yeong-Chae and an unnamed narrator), the interrogators use a pen as a weapon, symbolically suggesting the force of language. In the story, it's more often the case that the government succeeds in silencing speech, frightening characters away from giving words to their pain and anger. But even as *Human Acts* illustrates the state's very real ability to silence its citizens, the fact of the book's existence testifies to the power of language to overcome even the worst violence. The novel ends with the writer standing in a graveyard, paying her respects to an activist named Dong-ho who was murdered while still in middle school. Just by reading the novel, this final scene suggests, readers are remembering Dong-ho. In this way, then, language returns to Dong-ho—and to the novel's other silenced characters—some of the life and power that the state's violence and censorship took from him.



YOUTH, COURAGE, AND NAIVETY

Many of the characters in *Human Acts*, Han Kang's 2014 book about the 1980 Gwangju protests, become activists—and lose their lives for doing

so—while still children. On the one hand, the novel emphasizes the bravery that boys like Dong-ho and Jeong-dae, not yet in high school, possess. But on the other hand, Han's prose consistently demonstrates just how undeveloped these boys really were. When Dong-ho is killed, he is wearing his school gym uniform of a sweater and **trackpants**. Because he is still so small, the clothes don't fit him, hanging off his body "like a sack."

Even faced with extreme violence, Dong-ho and Yeong-chae, another young protestor, cannot stop thinking about their favorite sweet treats: Dong-ho wolfs down sponge cake, while Yeong-chae stays steely-eyed as he is tortured but breaks down while thinking about Sprite. By returning so frequently to these poignant images of youth, *Human Acts* reminds readers that children like Jeong-dae, Dong-ho, and Yeong-chae were not necessarily conscious political actors, nor were they always aware of the danger they were getting into—"you wanted to live," fellow activist Eun-sook recalls about Dong-ho, remembering how his eyelids trembled with fear. The novel examines the tragic losses during the Gwangju protests from many different angles. Above all, however, the novel demonstrates the utter horror of the South Korean government's violence against children. *Human Acts* also suggests that what may seem like courage in the novel's young characters is more akin to naivety, as the story's central young boys struggle to understand the potentially dangerous consequences of their acts of protest.



AFTERLIFE AND THE SOUL

Many times in Han Kang's novel *Human Acts*, survivors and victims of the 1980 Gwangju uprising contemplate what happens after death. Some

disillusioned characters, like an unnamed narrator who spends years being tortured in prison, believe that humans are only "filthy, stinking bodies," existing in the flesh or not at all. But other characters disagree. At the very beginning of the story, young protagonist Dong-ho recalls seeing his grandmother die: "something seemed to flutter up from her face," he thinks, a "winged thing" that he recognizes as a soul. After vicious state soldiers murder Dong-ho, many of his loved ones echo this idea of a "fluttering" soul, feeling Dong-ho's presence as they walk down the street or look at blooming flowers. And crucially, the narrative itself affirms this existence of a soul. The novel ends when a character known only as "the writer," a stand-in for Han herself, mourns at Dong-ho's grave; as she stands there, she stares at a flickering **candle**, a "fluttering [...] translucent wing" that, as in Dong-ho's earlier framing, signifies the presence of this young boy's soul. Perhaps more radically, the second chapter of *Human Acts* is narrated by Jeong-dae, one of Dong-ho's friends—but since Jeong-dae has already been murdered, he speaks only as his soul.

Emphasizing the presence of a tangible afterlife functions on a practical level, allowing Han to make important formal leaps: she can have Jeong-dae speak from beyond the grave or give Dong-ho's mother an opportunity to commune with her long-lost son. But more than that, this insistence on the reality of souls is an act of literary resistance, suggesting that the souls of the protestors the repressive state tried to exterminate can live on in Han's work.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



TRACKPANTS

In *Human Acts*, the trackpants that Dong-ho and Jeong-dae wear symbolize the youthful innocence that was destroyed during the Gwangju massacre. Even for middle schoolers, both Dong-ho and Jeong-dae are small for their age, meaning the exercise suits they wear as gym uniforms hang off them. But these oversized trackpants, initially representative of these boys' normal, playful, childhood (and of their physical vulnerability) take on new meaning after the 5:18 crackdown. When soldiers shoot down Jeong-dae during a protest, Dong-ho can only identify his friend's corpse by its pair of "light blue tracksuit bottoms, identical to [his] own." Later, after Dong-ho has been similarly murdered, everyone from Dong-ho's mother to the writer herself pictures the beloved boy in his oversized trackpants, an image that speaks to the adolescent phase Dong-ho was in when his life was taken. Yet if the recurring symbolism of trackpants symbolizes the tragedy of youth cut short, it also provides a sense of strength and continuity to those who outlive Dong-ho. When the writer gets caught in a snowbank, she pictures Dong-ho in his trackpants and finds herself newly able to withstand the cold. And when Eun-sook sees a young male actor wearing a tracksuit, the memories of Dong-ho embolden her: "scalding tears burn from [her] eyes" at the sight, "but she does not look away." In other words, trackpants represent the inhumanity of Dong-ho and Jeong-dae's murders, but they also represent the way the boys' memories ignite and inspire those that survived them.



CANDLES

Throughout Han Kang's novel *Human Acts*, candles symbolize the souls of the dead. Early on, when he is still working at the Provincial Office, Dong-ho implores Jin-su to get candles for all the corpses, hoping to honor the dead (and eliminate the smell of decay). Moreover, though Dong-ho does not explicitly make the connection, the appearance of a candle's flickering flame also reminds him of his grandmother's death, when "something"—which he later reflects must have been her soul—"seemed to flutter up from her face, like a bird escaping." As the story progresses, characters like Jeong-dae and Jin-su will echo this belief in the soul as a "fluttering" thing, impossible to touch yet tangibly present. In the final moments of the novel, the writer, having traveled to Dong-ho's grave, lights a candle for the murdered young boy, just as Dong-ho used to do for the murdered protestors back in 1980. As the candle flames, the writer notes its "wavering outline, fluttering like a bird's

translucent wing." The writer's language is clear: by honoring Dong-ho's memory in this way, she has allowed Dong-ho's soul to momentarily take shape on earth, "fluttering" in the candle's flame much like his grandmother's did all those years ago.



PENS AND INK

In *Human Acts*, author Han Kang presents language as a powerful tool of protest and resistance—so it is perhaps a surprise that in the novel, pens and ink are almost always associated with violence. The unnamed narrator and Jin-su, both taken prisoner after the Gwangju uprising, suffer when armed guards use expensive Monami Biro pens for excruciating forms of torture. And for Eun-sook, who is working covertly to publish dissident plays, looking at the pages the state censor's ink-roller has erased feels like being "burned." On the one hand, then, pens and ink symbolize Chun Doo-hwan's dictatorial efforts to silence any disagreement: he blots out protest art, rips up activists' fliers and posters, and tortures those who speak against him until they feel "utterly devoid of anything that could be said to resemble humanity."

But on the other hand, Chun Doo-hwan's commitment to destroying language also reflects the power words have to create real change. Even though the actors in the play Eun-sook works on are only allowed to mouth their lines, the shapes of the words are still enough to energize an entire audience. Dong-ho's mother, mourning her son, redraws every set of posters that Chun doo-hwan's soldiers shred, eventually helping to unseat the dictator. And Han Kang, by concluding her novel with a focus on the writer, a fictional stand-in for Han herself, emphasizes that language continues to bring justice to the victims of state violence. After all, readers of *Human Acts* are encountering this story through words, thus helping to remember a historical reality that Chun Doo-hwan is now powerless to erase.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Hogarth edition of *Human Acts* published in 2017.

Chapter 1: The Boy, 1980 Quotes

☞ Why would you sing the national anthem for people who've been killed by soldiers? Why cover the coffin with the Taegukgi? As though it wasn't the nation itself that had murdered them. [...]

"But the generals are rebels, they seize power unlawfully. You must have seen it: people being beaten and stabbed in broad daylight, and even shot. The ordinary soldiers were following the orders of their superiors. How can you call them the nation?"

You found this confusing, as though it had answered an entirely different question to the one you wanted to ask. The national anthem rang out like a circular refrain, one verse clashing with another against the constant background of weeping, and you listened with bated breath to the subtle dissonance this created. As though this, finally, might help you understand what the nation really was.

Related Characters: Eun-sook (speaker), Dong-ho, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 17

Explanation and Analysis

As the students of Gwangju protest Chun Doo-hwan—and mourn those killed by his militant regime—young Dong-ho wonders why the South Korean national anthem plays such a role in these funerals. His confusion is reasonable: it's the state, which the South Korean national anthem and the Taegukgi (the Korean national flag) honors, that ordered and paid for the violence that killed the dead. And even if, as Eun-sook argues, the "ordinary soldiers" are merely "following [...] orders," the crowd of soldiers killing people in the square is ostensibly doing so in the name of the nation's leader.

On the one hand, then, Dong-ho's hesitance to embrace the national anthem shows the danger inherent in crowds: when these soldiers come together, "ordinary" men are transformed into a seamlessly brutal whole. But on the other hand, Eun-sook believes that by joining her voice to sing the national anthem alongside her fellow protestors, she can reclaim what "the nation" really is. Instead of seeing crowd psychology as a source of violence, as Chun does, Eun-sook and the other young activists find strength in this chorus, taking comfort in standing—and singing—in solidarity with others.

It is telling that Dong-ho finds "dissonance" ("clashing") not only between these two ways of viewing the nation but

between these two ways of being in a crowd. Repeatedly, the novel will assert that crowds can bring out both the best and worst in people, sometimes nullifying morals and sometimes encouraging selflessness. Importantly, Dong-ho here frames "the nation" as the ultimate crowd. With the right leader in place, a nation can be liberatory, becoming the South Korea that Eun-sook tries to celebrate with the anthem and the Taegukgi. But with the wrong person in charge, the nation becomes a brutal, unthinking, murdering mob.

☞ "Let's go home," she says. You give your wrist a violent wrench, trying to shake free of her grip. The insistent, desperate strength in that grip is frightening, somehow, making you think of someone drowning. You have to use your other hand to pry her fingers away, one by one. "The army is coming. Let's go home, now."

[...] You turn around and call back to her: "We're going to close up here at six, Mum." [...] You call again, louder this time: "Once we've closed up, I'll come home. I promise."

[...] "Make sure you do," she says. "Be back before the sun sets. We'll all have dinner together."

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Dong-ho's Mother (speaker), The Middle Brother

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 44

Explanation and Analysis

Though Dong-ho knows that soldiers plan to re-invade Gwangju later tonight, he insists on staying at the Provincial Office to help deal with the corpses, ignoring his mother and middle brother's most desperate pleas. This poignant exchange juxtaposes Dong-ho's courageous decision to stay behind—even if it means facing almost certain death—with his youthful innocence. In scolding Dong-ho to be home for dinner, Dong-ho's mother plays out a familiar parent-child scene; she has likely made the same request dozens of times, when Dong-ho stayed out too late playing badminton with Jeong-dae or got caught up in his studying. But now the stakes are life and death, a warping that speaks to just how much all the normal routines of Dong-ho's childhood have been interrupted.

It is also worth noting how Dong-ho's uses of the pronoun "we" and "we're" contrasts with his mother's use of "we" to refer to their family unit. Tellingly, the "we" in question here

is not Dong-ho's family but the group of protestors that has become a different sort of family to Dong-ho. And though many of the other young activists are near-total strangers to Dong-ho, he now chooses to stay with this group rather than go home, choosing his sense of commitment to the crowd over comfort, safety, and even love for his family.

☞ Bending down to remove the cloth, your gaze is arrested by the sight of the translucent candle wax creeping down below the bluish flame.

How long do souls linger by the side of their bodies?

Do they really flutter away like some kind of bird? Is that what trembles the edges of the candle flame?

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Jeong-dae

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 46

Explanation and Analysis

Earlier, Dong-ho reflected on the “fluttering,” bird-like presence that seemed to fly away from his grandmother’s body when she died. Now, as he studies the corpses of people the state soldiers killed, he wonders if these bodies have similarly “fluttering” souls, looking down with shock at their brutalized “bodies.”

To some extent, this is a dismaying thought—as Jeong-dae will learn in the next chapter, there is nothing more terrifying than being forced to “linger” long enough to come to terms with one’s own bodily vulnerability. But there is also something resilient and expansive in Dong-ho’s belief that death does not necessarily mean the complete destruction of a person’s individual self. In conflating the “flutter[ing]” soul with the forces that “trembles the edges of the candle flame,” Dong-ho ascribes power and presence to those who have been murdered. Moreover, if souls come back as candle flames, they can provide solace to those who survive them, warming and lighting the earth even in moments of great pain. And importantly, the poetic framing of the soul as a “flutter[ing] candle flame” foreshadows some of the novel’s most frequently occurring symbolism.

Lastly, it is worth noting the second-person narration that Han has chosen for Dong-ho’s chapter. By putting readers so firmly in the perspective of its soon-to-be-murdered young boy, the novel ensures that its audience must feel Dong-ho’s “trembl[ing]” in their own minds just as Dong-ho

now feels these “translucent” souls around him. A candle is one form of memory, this literary framing seems to suggest, but the novel itself can be another one.

Chapter 2: The Boy’s Friend, 1980 Quotes

☞ Burning my tongue on a steamed potato my sister gave me, blowing on it hastily and juggling it in my mouth.

Flesh of a watermelon grainy as sugar, the glistening black seeds I didn’t bother to pick out.

Racing back to the house where my sister was waiting, my jacket zipped up over a parcel of chrysanthemum bread, feet entirely numb with cold, the bread blazing hot against my heart.

Yearning to be taller.

To be able to do forty push-ups in a row.

For the time when I would hold a woman in my arms.

Related Characters: Jeong-dae (speaker), Jeong-mi

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 59

Explanation and Analysis

In the present, Jeong-dae’s floating soul looks on as his murdered, mutilated body languishes in a pile of other corpses. As he tries to distract himself from his horrifying reality, Jeong-dae finds solace in quotidian memories: of eating too quickly and burning his tongue, of rushing home through the rain. These little recollections of normal physical discomfort have paradoxically now become comforting, reminding Jeong-dae of a time when his body could fuel him rather than merely tethering his soul to this awful place.

First, then, this passage suggests that memory can be rejuvenating, providing emotional sustenance even when the body itself fails to work. Second, in remembering his “yearning to be taller” and his craving to “hold a woman” in his arms, Jeong-dae’s musings here get at the impossible tragedy of a childhood cut short. Jeong-dae’s desires to have the standard experiences of adolescence—to grow physically and experientially, to do push-ups and have sex—can never be realized without a living body. And so the novel demonstrates that a child’s death holds two endings: the loss of the life the child had already lived, and the loss of the life the child still had in front of him.

●● I looked on in silence as my face blackened and swelled, my features turned into festering ulcers, the contours that had defined me, that had given me clear edges, crumbled into ambiguity, leaving nothing that could be recognized as me.

As the nights wore on, increasingly more shadows came and pressed up against my own. Our encounters were, as always, poorly improvised things. We were never able to tell who the other was, but could vaguely surmise how long we'd been together for. Every time our shadow boundaries brushed against each other, an echo of some appalling suffering was transmitted to me like an electric shock.

Related Characters: Jeong-dae (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 62

Explanation and Analysis

Though only a few short days pass in Jeong-dae's section of the narrative, decomposition works fast, so Jeong-dae's body "blacken[s]" and "swell[s]" almost in real time. This "festering" illustrates the fragility of the human body, a reality all of the characters in the story struggle to cope with. But more than that, the deterioration of Jeong-dae's body leads him to experience a strange, mirror-image version of the loss of self he felt as a protestor. In the crowds of activists, Jeong-dae could join a unified whole ("the miracle of stepping outside the shell of our own selves," as the unnamed narrator will put it in a later chapter). And strangely, as his corpse collapses, Jeong-dae feels a similar sensation: "the contours that had defined" him, his "shell" of sorts, give way as his "clear edges" dissolve into the pile of carnage around him.

It is also worth noting the silent, almost intuitive form of understanding Jeong-dae reaches with his fellow victims. For many of the characters in *Human Acts*, written words are an essential form of communication and protest. But here, the only language is "appalling suffering," as each separate being feels now entirely reduced to their pain. And as the "shadow boundaries" break down, so does a sense of each individual's life before and beyond the horrific state violence they have experienced.

Chapter 3: The Editor, 1985 Quotes

●● His face was utterly ordinary. Thin lips, no noticeable irregularities to his features. He wore a pale yellow shirt with a wide collar, and his gray suit trousers were held up by a belt. Its buckle gleamed. Had they met by chance in the street, she would have taken him for some run-of-the-mill company manager or section chief.

"Bitch. A bitch like you, in a place like this? Anything could happen, and no one would find out."

At this point, the force of the slap had already burst the capillaries in her cheek and the man's fingernails had broken her skin. But Eun-sook hadn't known that yet.

Related Characters: The Interrogator (speaker), Dong-ho, Eun-sook, Jin-su, President Chun Doo-hwan, The Translator

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 69

Explanation and Analysis

Eun-sook, whom the local police have summoned to their station due to her work with a controversial translator, is shocked when the interrogator's questioning turns into violence—seven slaps in a row, to be exact. As she obsessively recalls the slaps in the following days, Eun-sook finds herself stuck on the idea that such an "utterly ordinary" person could commit such an extraordinarily brutal act. Indeed, nearly every phrase of this passage gestures towards this man's seeming normalcy: he has "no noticeable irregularities" in his features to signal his cruelty, and his pastel, "run-of-the-mill" outfit makes him seem like a middle manager more than a violent officer of the state. Previously, the novel has shown that ordinary people like Dong-ho and Jin-su can, under the right circumstances, commit incredible acts of bravery and generosity. Now, the interrogator reverses that principle—empowered by the state to be brutal, this "utterly ordinary" man becomes a monster.

There are two other important details in Eun-sook's flashback here. First, the interrogator's use of the word "bitch" hints at the misogyny undergirding his slaps, a facet of Chun's state terror that Seon-ju's section of *Human Acts* explores in greater depth. Moreover, the interrogator's threat that "anything could happen, and no one would find out" also implies sexual violence—because he is acting as an arm of the state, the interrogator seems to see himself as above the law.

Second, it is important to pay attention to the level of detail Han provides about the way the slaps function biologically.

The man's fingernails shred Eun-sook's skin, while his force simultaneously bruises her beneath her flesh, "burst[ing] the capillaries" deep in her cheek. Violence at this scale and frequency, the narrative seems to suggest, makes those who experience it more aware of how their bodies function—and of how easily that functioning can be disrupted.

- Her initial impression is that the pages have been burned. They've been thrown onto a fire and left to blacken [...]

More than half of the sentences in the ten-page introduction have been scored through. In the thirty or so pages following, this percentage rises so that the vast majority of sentences have aligned through them. From around the fifth page onward, perhaps because drawing a line had become too labor-intensive, entire pages have been blacked out, presumably using an ink roller [...]

She recalls sentences roughly darned and patched, places where the forms of words can just about be made out in paragraphs that had been otherwise expunged. *You. I. That. Perhaps. Precisely. Everything. You. Why. Gaze. Your eyes. Near and far. That. Vividly. Now. A little more. Vaguely. Why did you. Remember?* Gasping for breath in these interstices, tiny islands among language charred out of existence.

Related Characters: Eun-sook, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 80

Explanation and Analysis

As someone who works at a publishing house in the early years of Chun Doo-hwan's regime, Eun-sook is used to turning all new manuscripts over to state censors, who are then supposed to cross out any words or phrases they see as seditious. But when she delivers this collection of newly translated plays (the same collection she was slapped for), the censors have gone much further, censoring so much of the text that its meaning is nullified. It is telling that when Eun-sook returns to the text, she can only find sentence fragments. The words that might hint at grief and mourning ("near and far," "your eyes") now are reduced to meaninglessness; though the plays ask their readers to "remember," the censors have erased any narrative that could require remembrance. Therefore, instead of being a tool of communication, language now becomes one more

thing that isolates Eun-sook—she is a "tiny island," unable to cross the seas of the censors' ink-roller.

It is especially telling that Eun-sook frames this censorship as a form of almost murderous violence—the meaning has been "charred out of existence," "burned" and "left to blacken." In the right hands, Eun-sook knows, language can be a powerful tool of protest and unity. But pens and ink-rollers can also be metaphorically (and, later, literally) weaponized. After all, if Chun knows that words can contest his brutal power, he will try to exert his brutal power over words, erasing even the most abstracted forms of dissent.

- As she silently chewed the grains of rice, it occurred to her, as it had before, that there was something shameful about eating. Gripped by this familiar shame, she thought of the dead, for whom the absence of life meant they would never be hungry again. But life still lingered on for her, with hunger still a yoke around her neck. It was that which had tormented her for the past five years—that she could still feel hunger, still salivate at the sight of food.

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Jeong-dae, Eun-sook, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 86

Explanation and Analysis

Though five years have passed since the 1980 Gwangju massacre, each of Eun-sook's days continues to be shaped by the horrors she witnessed there. Fascinatingly, while the characters themselves do not have the language of "survivor's guilt," that is what Eun-sook feels here: she finds "eating," the most basic act of survival, to be "shameful" when so many are dead (meaning they will "never be hungry again"). Eun-sook's question each time she craves food, clearly hinted at but unspoken, is why she deserves to have life "linger on" while Dong-ho and others like him, even younger than she was, do not.

Yet even as Eun-sook despairs at the "yoke" of hunger around her neck, it is also important that her body wants her to survive even if her mind does not. She can still "salivate" at the sight of food, suggesting an instinctual excitement that Chun's violence has yet to fully quash. And if she has any sort of will to live, Eun-sook will later discover, then she can also use her still-working body—still "hungry," still "chew[ing]"—to honor and fight for those who can no

longer eat.

☛ She could have pressed her hands over her ears, could have screwed her eyes tight shut, shook her head from side to side or moaned in distress. Instead, she simply remembered you, Dong-ho. How you darted away at the stairs when she tried to take you home. Your face frozen with terror, as though escaping this importunate plea was your only hope of survival. *Let's go together, Dong-ho. We ought to leave together, right away.* You stood there clinging to the second-floor railing, trembling. When she caught your gaze, Eun-sook saw your eyelids quiver. Because you were afraid. Because you wanted to live.

Related Characters: Eun-sook (speaker), Dong-ho, Dong-ho's Mother, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 93

Explanation and Analysis

In the moments after Chun Doo-hwan's soldiers invaded Gwangju, Eun-sook thought not of the danger she herself was in but of Dong-ho—his “terror,” the youth evident in his “trembling” and his hands “clinging” to the railing. Most of all, Eun-sook remembers Dong-ho's naivety: even as he is staying behind and risking his life, he seems unsure of his decision, desperately “want[ing] to live” but winding up dead almost by default. This pivotal moment, in which a middle school boy had to make a decision far beyond his pre-teen processing capacity, will haunt Eun-sook (and the rest of the characters) forever, making it one more reason why this child's death is uniquely tragic.

But even as Eun-sook mourns Dong-ho, she also remains deeply connected to him. The novel's use of second person perspective here (“you stood there,” Eun-sook thinks, “you wanted to live”) turns the reader into Dong-ho, allowing all those who pick up the novel to experience the sense of solidarity and care that those young protestors offered each other during the 5:18 uprising. And so while Dong-ho did not get to “physically” live, Eun-sook's letter of sorts allows him another life in her readers.

Lastly, there are two notable moments of foreshadowing in this passage. First, the image of Dong-ho's “quiver[ing]” eyelids echoes the “fluttering” language the book uses often to describe human souls, suggesting that in making this decision, Dong-ho is already transitioning to the afterlife.

And second, Eun-sook's pleading with Dong-ho to leave—a moment that seems to remain a source of deep guilt for her—echoes Dong-ho's mother's similar experience with her son.

☛ Certain crowds do not blench at the prospect of looting, murder, and rape, while on the other hand, others display a level of courage and altruism which those making up that same crowd would have had difficulty in achieving as individuals. The author argues that, rather than this latter type of crowd being made-up of especially noble individuals, that nobility which is a fundamental human attribute is able to manifest itself through borrowing strength from the crowd; also, similarly, that the former case is one in which humanity's essential barbarism is exacerbated not by the especially barbaric nature of any of the individuals involved, but through that magnification which occurs naturally in crowds.

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Eun-sook, Jin-su, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 96

Explanation and Analysis

While she is working late one day at the publishing office, Eun-sook opens a scholarly book about the psychology of crowds (also frequently termed “mob mentality” or “groupthink”). This excerpt gives theoretical backing to what many of the characters have already learned first-hand: that crowds made up of “individuals” transcend and transform those individuals' traits. On the one hand, crowds can make people who would not normally be “especially noble”—like Dong-ho, Jin-su, and perhaps Eun-sook herself—find extraordinary courage and selflessness by “borrowing” from the communal energy. On the other hand, crowds can make people who would not be “barbaric” on their own behave in brutal, seemingly inhuman ways. This dark side of the “magnification which occurs naturally in crowds” can be seen in the young soldiers who carry out Chun Doo-hwan's brutal orders, and in the interrogator who slapped Eun-sook again and again and again.

Once more, this passage highlights—albeit from a scholarly perspective rather than a personal one—the way that being part of a crowd erases individual selfhood. Seen through this lens, the piecemeal structure of the novel makes sense: by focusing on one character at a time, author Han is returning individuality to those who have, at least

temporarily, given it up.

☞ Eun-sook closes her eyes. She does not want to see his face.

After you died I couldn't hold a funeral, so my life became a funeral.

After you were wrapped in a tarpaulin and carted away in a garbage truck.

After sparkling jets of water sprayed unforgivably from the fountain.

Everywhere the lights of the temple shrines are burning.

In the flowers that bloom in spring, in the snowflakes. In the evenings that draw each day to a close. Sparks from the candles, burning in empty drinks bottles.

Scalding tears burn from Eun-sook's open eyes, but she does not wipe them away. She glares fiercely at the boy's face, at the movement of his silenced lips.

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Eun-sook, Mr. Seo

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 104

Explanation and Analysis

Though the state has censored most of the protest play producer Mr. Seo had hoped to put onstage, he finds a clever workaround. Rather than having actors speak the censored words, he will have actors silently mouth this language. One of those actors is a young boy in trackpants, his silence onstage reminding Eun-sook of the way Dong-ho was violently silenced. At first, Eun-sook cannot bear to look at this little boy's face—but she cannot escape the pain even when she “closes her eyes.” In her mind, censored phrases from the play (“after you died I couldn't hold a funeral, so my life became a funeral”) mix with other memories of erasure (the fountains that “sprayed unforgivably” as if no violence had ever happened in Gwangju, the streams of bodies “carted away” out of sight).

Midway through these italicized phrases, however, Eun-sook's images change. Rather than thinking about erasure, she begins to think about memory and survival: the temple lights still “burning,” the flowers that still “bloom,” and the “candles” that Dong-ho lit. These new images prompt Eun-sook to open her eyes, choosing to remember even if it makes her cry—to recall Dong-ho into being in her mind just as this little boy recalls him onstage. And this decision to remember allows Eun-sook to approach the world in a

newly “fierce” way.

Finally, it is significant that Eun-sook sees an image of a candle in her mind at this exact moment in the play. Throughout the narrative, candles symbolize souls. When a flame flickers, several characters suggest, it is a sign of a soul's tangible presence. In a metaphysical sense, then, as a well a metaphorical one, Dong-ho is present as this radical play unfolds.

Chapter 4: The Prisoner, 1990 Quotes

☞ It wasn't as though we didn't know how overwhelmingly the army outnumbered us. But the strange thing was, it didn't matter. Ever since the uprising began, I'd felt something coursing through me, as overwhelming as an army.

Conscience.

Conscience, the most terrifying thing in the world. The day I stood shoulder to shoulder with hundreds of thousands of my fellow civilians, staring down the barrels of the soldiers' guns, [...] I was startled to discover an absence inside myself: the absence of fear. I remember feeling that it was all right to die; I felt the blood of a hundred thousand hearts surging together into one enormous artery, fresh and clean...the sublime enormity of a single heart, pulsing blood through that vessel and into my own. I dared to feel a part of it.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 115

Explanation and Analysis

Ten years after the Gwangju uprising of 1980, this unnamed narrator is still trying to understand how he was capable of such incredible fearlessness at the young age of 22. In this passage, which echoes the theories of crowd psychology in Eun-sook's section, the narrator feels as if he were similarly able to borrow strength from the crowd. Indeed, the narrator speaks as if the crowd were almost one body: though his individual form might be shot down, “a hundred thousand hearts” would keep beating, and the “enormous artery” of this unified crowd would keep “pulsing blood.” Thus, two of the novel's central themes come together—each person's body may be fragile, but the physical “vessel” of the crowd is “sublime” and “enormous,” more “terrifying” than the barrels of any soldiers' guns.

The narrator's reflections on conscience here reflect the beauty of a crowd's “single heart.” But the “absence of fear”

he recalls feeling, while noble, was also irrational—almost “terrifying[ly]” so. Even as the narrator’s reflections testify to the amazing bravery of the young protestors in the 5:18 uprising, then, it also gestures towards the naivety of a crowd, the sense that as the crowd’s strength pumps “into” each person’s body, that person’s ability to make their own decisions gets pumped out.

☛ Kids crouching beneath the windows, fumbling with their guns and complaining that they were hungry, asking if it was OK for them to quickly run back and fetch the sponge cake and Fanta they’d left in the conference room; what could they possibly have known about death that would have enabled them to make such a choice?

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Dong-ho, Jin-su, Yeong-chae

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 117

Explanation and Analysis

Though he was by no means a mature adult the time of the Gwangju protests, the narrator (like his colleague and friend Jin-su) was no longer a teenager. But pre-teens Dong-ho, Yeong-chae, and their friends had yet to enter high school when violence swept through their city. Here, the narrator comments on the central tragedy of the novel: Dong-ho could not choose to stay behind, facing the soldiers’ brutality, because he did not yet have the logic “to make such a choice.” Rather than facing the gravity of the situation, these “kids” are “fumbling” with weapons they do not know how to use and complaining of hunger, signs of their youthful clumsiness and naivety. After all, what middle-schooler can see the big picture, thinking beyond their need immediate needs and cravings?

The narrator’s mention of soda and sponge cake, beloved by both Dong-ho and Yeong-chae, is particularly poignant. First, these sweet treats exemplify the boys’ unsophisticated tastes, their childish desire for candy strong even in a moment of crisis. And second, these quotidian snacks mark just how much all normalcy has been destroyed. Yeong-chae, who meets torture and imprisonment with a steely calm, breaks down into tears at the mere mention of Fanta. Even more unbearable than what these boys experience, it seems, is the weight of what they will not get to experience—Dong-ho and Yeong-chae will never get to outgrow the Fanta and sponge cake they

spent their last moments longing for.

☛ At that moment, I realized what all this was for. The words that this torture and starvation were intended to elicit. *We will make you realize how ridiculous it was, the lot of you waving the national flag and singing the national anthem. We will prove to you that you are nothing but filthy, stinking bodies. That you are no better than the carcasses of starving animals.*

[...] Watery discharge and sticky puss, foul saliva, blood, tears and snot, piss and shit that soiled your pants. That was all that was left to me. No, that was what I myself had been reduced to. I was nothing but the sum of those parts. The lump of rotting meat from which they oozed was the only “me” there was.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Yeong-chae, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 120

Explanation and Analysis

Amid the protesting crowds, the narrator felt as if he were almost superhuman, just one facet of “the sublime enormity of a single heart.” But after months of imprisonment and torture at the hands of Chun Doo-hwan’s soldiers, the narrator no longer feels like he is a member of a massive whole; instead, he is “nothing but the sum of [his] parts,” “reduced” to the sticky liquids of the human body. The contrast could not be starker—“singing the national anthem” in unison allowed the narrator to transcend his physical limits, only to have to reconceive of himself as a “lump of rotting meat” at the hands of his punishers.

First, then, the state’s torture is effective by making those who once felt strong become hyper-aware of their physical vulnerabilities—the narrator sees himself and his co-prisoners as “nothing but filthy, stinking bodies,” “carcasses” without selfhood or soul. But it is also important to track how the state uses torture to force language, changing the narrative of the protests by physically distorting the prisoners’ words. The narrator knows that above all else, “words” are the thing “this torture and starvation were intended to elicit.” And by compelling the prisoners, through the sheer intensity of their pain, to speak the words Chun wants them to speak, the soldiers claim power not just over each person’s body but over their inner life. After all, as the

narrator puts it, once the torturers have seized his meaning away from him, they have also taken his entire sense of himself as a “me.”

☞ Looking at that boy's life, Jin-su said, what is this thing we call a soul? Just some nonexistent idea? Or something that might as well not exist? Or no, is it like a kind of glass? Glass is transparent, right? And fragile. That's the fundamental nature of glass. And that's why objects that are made of glass have to be handled with care. After all, if they end up smashed or cracked or chipped, then they're good for nothing, right, you just have to chuck them away.

Before, we used to have a kind of glass that couldn't be broken. A truth so hard and clear it might as well have been made of glass. So when you think about it, it was only when we were shattered that we proved we had souls. Though what we really were was humans made of glass.

Related Characters: Jin-su, The Narrator (speaker), Dong-ho, Yeong-chae

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 130

Explanation and Analysis

Years after being imprisoned with Yeong-chae and the narrator, Jin-su learns that Yeong-chae has been institutionalized for a violent outburst. Yeong-chae's struggle makes Jin-su think of Dong-ho, also a middle-schooler at the time of the Gwangju uprising—and the sheer tragedy of what Yeong-chae and Dong-ho have had to experience finally causes Jin-su's collapse. *Human Acts* has made it clear that a soul can survive physical violence, as when Jeong-dae's soul narrates from beyond the grave. But Jin-su's sense of being utterly “shattered” here suggests that souls can be destroyed by senseless tragedy, by a sense that there is no moral “truth,” no matter how “hard and clear” it once seemed. Even as Jin-su's speech affirms the reality of the soul, then, it also suggests a more nihilistic view of the world than any of the characters have yet espoused. Indeed, in Jin-su's mind, the soul can be killed, too; it is perhaps unsurprising, then, that Jin-su soon chooses to take his own life.

Moreover, Jin-su's musings here—written in italics instead of quotes to reflect their weight and lyricism—emphasize how vulnerable the body is once the soul is taken away. As someone who was tortured for months, Jin-su knows firsthand what it means to be “smashed or cracked or

chipped,” metaphorically and literally. This passage thus adds one more layer to the novel's overall concern with bodily vulnerability, acknowledging the force of biology while suggesting that true life force comes from something beyond one's cells.

☞ I heard a story about one of the Korean army platoons that fought in Vietnam. How they forced the women, children, and elderly of one particular village into the main hall, and then burned it to the ground. Some of those who claim to slaughter us did so with the memory of those previous times, when committing such actions and wartime had won them a handsome reward. It happened in Gwangju just as it did on Jeju Island, [...] in Bosnia, and all across the American continent when it was still known as the new world, with such a uniform brutality it's as though it is imprinted in our genetic code. I never let myself forget that every single person I meet is a member of this human race.

[...] So tell me, professor, what answers do you have for me? You, a human being just like me.

Related Characters: The Narrator (speaker), Eun-sook, The Professor/Yoon

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator has experienced crowds mostly as a force for good, finding comfort and solidarity as he stood along thousands of other young protestors. But Eun-sook's book about crowd psychology was clear that “humanity's essential barbarism” could also be exacerbated “through that magnification which occurs naturally in crowds”—and now, the narrator must address how crowds can provoke cruelty, too. In this critical passage, the narrator suggests that this seemingly extraordinary cruelty (abusing children and the elderly, setting whole buildings on fire) is in fact commonplace. The narrator suggests that brutality is in humans' “genetic code,” with unthinkable cruel acts happening all over the world and across history, from the violent colonization of the Americas to the horrific Bosnian genocide.

And if everyone has the capacity to commit such brutal acts, from an “utterly ordinary” interrogator in South Korea to a profit-hungry settler of the United States, how can the narrator ever trust anyone again? In this final line of his section, the narrator poses exactly this question to the

professor (later revealed to be Yoon). While the professor may claim to want to help, how can he differentiate himself from those who share that same “genetic code”? And worst of all, how can the narrator even trust himself—also a “human being,” and therefore also capable of such cruelty—to know the difference?

Chapter 5: The Factory Girl, 2002 Quotes

☛ The repeated words from Yoon’s e-mail, a pianist hammering the same keys, flicker in your mind’s eye like a cursor blinking on a computer screen. Testimony. Meaning. Memory. For the future.

[...] Again, you experienced that moment when the contours of suffering coalesce into clarity, a clarity colder and harder than any nightmare could ever be. The moment when you are forced to acknowledge that what you experienced was no mere dream.

[...] Yoon has asked you to remember. To face up to those memories, to bear witness to them. But how can such a thing be possible?

Related Characters: Seon-ju, President Chun Doo-hwan, The Professor/Yoon

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 164

Explanation and Analysis

Nearly a decade after receiving an interview request from Professor Yoon, Seon-ju is still deliberating about whether or not she can revisit the events of the Gwangju uprising for this scholarly project (what Yoon calls a “psychological autopsy”). On the one hand, Seon-ju is well aware of what her interview could mean—she has always known words have the power to make “meaning” and preserve “memory,” that her “testimony” about the past could help prevent such events from happening in “the future.” But on the other hand, the “nightmare” Seon-ju lived through, filled with horrific sexual violence and the loss of loved ones, is impossible to “face up to.” Even almost two decades after Chun Doo-hwan lost power, then, the silencing effect of his state terror persists. And the very people who could best “testi[fy]” to the scope of these events are so scarred by their memories, both emotionally and physically, that revisiting them might not be “possible.”

☛ Some weekend afternoon when the sun-drenched scene outside the window seems unusually still and Dong-ho’s profile flips into your mind, mightn’t the thing flickering in front of your eyes be what they call a soul? In the early hours of the morning, when dreams you can’t remember have left your cheeks wet and the contours of that face jolt into an abrupt clarity, mightn’t that wavering be a soul’s emergence? And the place they emerged from, that they waver back into, would it be as black as night or dusk’s coarse weave? Dong-ho, Jin-su, the bodies at your own hands washed and dressed, might they be gathered there in that place, or are they sundered, several, scattered? You are aware that, as an individual, you have the capacity for neither bravery nor strength.

Related Characters: Dong-ho, Jeong-dae, Jin-su, Seon-ju, The Professor/Yoon

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 172

Explanation and Analysis

Seon-ju’s section of the novel is the least plot-driven and the most poetic—frequently, it is hard to tell what is a dream and what is a memory, or where the past is leaching into the present. In this passage, Seon-ju wonders if “what they call a soul” might function in the same way, flitting in and out of presence just as her thoughts do. And more than just affirming the concept of the soul as a tangible, “flickering” thing, Seon-ju begins to wonder about the mechanics of this possible afterlife. Specifically, she suspects that souls might have “contours”—hinting that each soul is a separate being with unique, distinct edges, a contrast to the blurring Jeong-dae experiences as a corpse and the rush Dong-ho and others feel in a crowd.

Yet even as Seon-ju imagines this more individualistic version of the soul, she also embraces the sense of community that can be found in a crowd. She hopes that Dong-ho, Jin-su, and other loved ones who have died are “gathered” together instead of “several, scattered”; she recalls, seemingly with some measure of pride, her own care and commitment to the dead. But most of all, Seon-ju knows that “as an individual,” she—or maybe “you,” the reader—lacks the “capacity for bravery or strength” that she has in a group. Seon-ju’s use of the phrase “as an individual” implies her sense that she is someone different in a group. And indeed, when Seon-ju is working alongside Eun-sook, or when she sees Dong-ho’s or Seong-hee’s faces in her mind, she finds the courage she needs to look to the past and to move forward into the future.

☝ If I demanded that you go home, Dong-ho; if I'd begged, while we sat there eating gimbap, you would have done as I asked, wouldn't you?

And that's why you're coming to me now.

To ask why I'm still alive.

You walk, your eyes red rim seeming carved with some keen blade. Hurrying back to the bright lights of the emergency department.

There's only one thing for me to say to you, onni.

If you'll allow me to.

If you'll please allow me.

[...] As you walk along the straight white line that follows the center of the road, you raise your head to the falling rain.

Don't die.

Just don't die.

Related Characters: Seon-ju (speaker), Dong-ho, Eun-sook, Jin-su, Seong-hee

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 174

Explanation and Analysis

Toward the end of her chapter, Seon-ju expresses some of the guilt Jin-su and Eun-sook share—that she could have saved Dong-ho by highlighting the extremity of their shared circumstance, chastising him instead of feeding him. But rather than beating herself up for the past, Seon-ju decides to reframe her sense of survivor's guilt. If she is “still alive,” she reasons, then she needs to find a purpose for her life (the “why” Dong-ho seems to ask about). For Seon-ju, her survival then takes on both personal and political meaning. She will return to her old friend Seong-hee (whom she calls “onni”, or older sister), mending their bond in order to express gratitude for her still-going life. And it also means that she will “raise [her] head to the falling rain,” quite literally “facing up”—and probably testifying—to the memories she has so long repressed.

It is also important here to note the way this passage, and Seon-ju's section of the novel in general, uses second-person perspective. At first, the “you” very clearly refers to Dong-ho. Then it shifts, and the “you”—“you experienced,” “you [...] remember”—seems to be Seon-ju herself, as if she is talking to herself in a mirror. And then the “you” begins to refer to Seon-ju's old friend and co-organizer Seong-hee. The second-person thus creates, on a formal level, the same feelings of connection and loss of self that Seon-ju and the other characters feel on the level of experience; readers,

too, must wonder where they end and the characters begin, as one “you” blurs into another.

Lastly, it is worth recalling that at the beginning of the novel, Dong-ho suggested that falling rain could be seen as “the tears of souls.” Just as Eun-sook and the writer encounter some physical manifestation of Dong-ho's soul, Seon-ju seems to be cheered by this tangible presence of her lost loved one.

Chapter 6: The Boy's Mother, 2010 Quotes

☝ Middle-school boys all had their hair cut short back then, didn't they, but it seems to have gone out of fashion now. That's how I knew it had to be you—I'd know that round little chestnut of a head anywhere. It was you, no mistake. Your brother's handme-down school uniform was like a sack on you, wasn't it? It took you till the third year to finally grow into it. In the mornings when you slipped out through the main gate with your book bag, and your clothes so neat and clean, ah, I could have gazed on that sight all day. This kid didn't have any book bag with him; the hands swinging by his sides were empty. Well, he must have put it down somewhere. There was no mistaking those toothpick arms, poking out of your short shirt sleeves [...] It was definitely you.

Related Characters: Dong-ho's Mother (speaker), Dong-ho

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 175

Explanation and Analysis

A full 30 years after the 5:18 massacre that killed her son, Dong-ho's mother still imagines that she sees her beloved child in the crowds of middle-schoolers that pass by her on the streets. As she follows this strange child through the streets, Dong-ho's mother is struck primarily by the vulnerability this young boy shares with Dong-ho himself: he is too small for the school uniform (complete with symbolic trackpants) that hangs “like a sack,” with “toothpick arms” that seem too frail to even carry a bookbag. Tragically, then, it seems that the quality Dong-ho's mother most associates with her son is his vulnerability, his pre-pubescent body a symbol of all the growing he never got to do.

Yet even as this section implies that Dong-ho's mother is distorting reality, the back and forth of her thoughts also

suggests that she is fully possessed of her senses. She knows that this boy in 2010 has a different haircut, that he lacks Dong-ho's signature backpack; even as she assures herself that this boy is Dong-ho, readers can sense the overcompensation in phrases like "it had to be you" and "it was definitely you." More than just missing Dong-ho, it seems, his mother is trying to manifest him, as if by longing for him with all her might she can create his presence.

Finally, after Seon-ju's shifting use of second-person perspective and the tell-tale word "you," it is worth noting how consistently Dong-ho's mother addresses her words to her son. By having Dong-ho's mother speak exclusively to Dong-ho himself, Han once again emphasizes how squarely this woman has devoted the remainder of her life to her murdered child.

☝ "I don't like summer but I like summer nights": that was something you came out with the year you turned eight. I liked the sound of those words, and I remember thinking to myself, *he'll be a poet*. Times when you three boys sat out on the bench in the yard, sharing watermelon with your father on hot summer nights. When your tongue groped for the sticky sweet remnants smeared around your mouth.

Related Characters: Dong-ho's Mother (speaker), Dong-ho, Jeong-dae, The Middle Brother, Dong-ho's Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 189

Explanation and Analysis

Recently widowed and still desperately missing her son, Dong-ho's mother has created a morning ritual: she traces her finger over Dong-ho's school ID and recalls her favorite memories with him, separating his life as much as possible from the 1980 state violence that killed him. Here, Dong-ho's mother remembers Dong-ho biting into a juicy watermelon, when his body could still metabolize food and find delight in it. The memory signals Dong-ho's youth—he loved "sticky sweet" things, it seems, whether that was watermelon or Sprite or sponge cake. It also recalls his friendship with Jeong-dae, who loved watermelon.

But perhaps most importantly, this reflection frames Dong-ho as a budding "poet." If Dong-ho loved the "sound" of words, playing with language even as an eight-year-old boy, then a well-crafted novel is the perfect container for his memorial. Each moment of stylization in *Human Acts*, each instance of literary flair, thus pays tribute to Dong-ho—the

central "you" of the novel—not only in content but in form. And while the poems Dong-ho might have written will never be seen, the prose he inspired can now reach readers all over the world.

Epilogue: The Writer, 2013 Quotes

☝ There was something meek and gentle about those single-lidded half-moon eyes. The traces of infancy still lingered in the soft line of his jaw. It was a face so utterly ordinary you could easily have mistaken it for that of another, a face whose characteristics would be forgotten the moment you turned away from it.

Related Characters: The Writer (speaker), Dong-ho, Eun-sook, Seon-ju, Dong-ho's Mother

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 198

Explanation and Analysis

To research an upcoming book about the 5:18 uprising, the writer—a close stand-in for the novel's author Han Kang—returns to her hometown of Gwangju, where she visits the 5:18 Research Institute. This real place, a public museum that focuses on the horrors that happened in May of 1980, features pictures and videos of many of those killed in the massacre. In the story, one of these pictures appears to be of Dong-ho, with his youthful features ("the traces of infancy" that "still lingered in the soft line of his jaw") and his gentle gaze.

Fascinatingly, however, the writer does not emphasize the traits that make young Dong-ho distinct. Instead, she describes his physical appearance as "utterly ordinary," the exact same words Eun-sook used to describe the brutal interrogator. There is nothing about Dong-ho that suggested he would behave with such incredible selflessness and bravery—he possessed no physical "characteristics" that indicate he would play such a memorable role in history. Yet just as Eun-sook's chapter emphasized that "utterly ordinary" people could be capable of great cruelty under one set of circumstances, the writer's reflection here shows that even the most seemingly "forgettable" person can rise to an occasion in unforgettable ways. And though Dong-ho's face might blur if the writer turns away from it, she—like Eun-sook and Seon-ju and Dong-ho's mother before her—will never let themselves "turn away."

●● As it turned out, none of my relatives died; none were injured or even arrested. But all through that autumn in 1980, my thoughts returned to that tiny room at one end of the kitchen, where I used to lie on my stomach to do my homework, that room with the cold paper floor—had the boy used it to spread out his homework on its cold paper floor, then lie stomach-down just as I had? The middle-school kid I'd heard the grown-ups whispering about. How had the seasons kept on turning for me, when time had stopped forever for him that May?

Related Characters: The Writer (speaker), Dong-ho, The Writer's Father

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 205

Explanation and Analysis

While the writer and her family were able to move to the capital city of Seoul several months before the worst violence in Gwangju, many of the writer's family members—like Dong-ho and his family—remained in Gwangju during the 5:18 uprising. But though the writer's relatives all survive, her sense of connection extends far beyond her own immediate bloodline. Instead, the writer begins to view her own active childhood in parallel to Dong-ho's lost youth, comparing her normal routines (lying "stomach-down" to do homework, making dinner) with the absence of routine in his life.

As the writer wonders why "the seasons kept on turning" for her even as they cease for Dong-ho, she is echoing the feeling of survivor's guilt that nearly every character in the novel seems to struggle with. Crucially, however, the writer never met Dong-ho: she feels kinship with him because she feels kinship with the people of Gwangju and because she understands herself as a member of a metaphorical crowd. Thus even in the absence of physical protest action, the writer grows up with the same group mentality that her young counterparts in Gwangju put into practice.

●● *Permission? Yes, you have my permission, but only if you do it properly. Please, write your book so that no one will ever be able to desecrate my brother's memory again [...]*

Whenever we had a toe war, I always won.

He was really ticklish, you see.

All I had to do was poke his foot with my big toe and he'd start squirming.

At first I couldn't tell whether he was grimacing like that because he was ticklish, or because it really hurt...

But then he would turn bright red and laugh.

Related Characters: The Middle Brother (speaker), Dong-ho, The Writer, Dong-ho's Mother, President Chun Doo-hwan

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 209

Explanation and Analysis

After some initial hesitance, the middle brother here agrees to an interview with the writer, giving his blessing to her as she starts to write her book about Dong-ho's life. Tellingly, in insisting that the writer "write [her] book so that no one will ever be able to desecrate my brother's memory again," the middle brother directly equates language with memory and power. In other words, by telling Dong-ho's story and "do[ing] it properly," the writer can use language to reclaim and re-remember the personal and large-scale history Chun's government worked so hard to erase.

It is also important to note what specific details the middle brother chooses to share with the writer (or at least which of those details the writer opts to include in her final book). The middle brother emphasizes Dong-ho's youth, but he also emphasizes his playfulness, his "squirming," giddy approach to these childhood games. By asking the writer to include such seemingly irrelevant minutiae, the middle brother is ensuring that Dong-ho's life will be told outside of the context of its brutal ending. And more than that, Dong-ho at last emerges as an individual, defined not by his circumstances but by his "bright red" laughter.

●● I didn't pray. I didn't close my eyes, or observe a minute silence. The candles burned steadily. Their orange flames undulating soundlessly, gradually being sucked into the center and hollowed out. Only then did I notice how incredibly cold my ankles were. Without realizing it, I'd been kneeling in a snowdrift that covered Dong-ho's grave. The snow had soaked through my socks, seeping in right through to my skin. I stared, mute, at that flame's wavering outline, fluttering like a bird's translucent wing.

Related Characters: The Writer (speaker), Dong-ho

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 212

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, which concludes the novel, the writer ventures through the snow to visit Dong-ho's gravestone in Gwangju. Moments before, the writer hallucinated that

Dong-ho himself appeared in front of her, guiding her through the snow and to the "flowers" (though she quickly reminded herself that no such thing is possible). Yet staring at the flame, it is clear within the novel's symbolic framework that Dong-ho's soul is somehow present. Since Dong-ho lit candles back at the Provincial Office, flickering candle flames have been a symbol for the soul's "fluttering" persistence. And just as Dong-ho's grandmother's soul seemed to be a "bird's translucent wing," the writer now implies that Dong-ho's spirit has just taken this kind of avian shape in front of her.

Ending the book this way has several important implications. First, the writer's sense of connection to Dong-ho's soul, as well the sense of comfort she gets from the "steady" burning of that symbolic candle, overrides her temporary physical pain (her "incredibly cold" ankles). Second, by finishing with this "fluttering" outline of Dong-ho's soul, the writer asks her readers to picture the book's protagonist separate from the violence he suffered—and to see him in their own lives, in every candle's flame.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1: THE BOY, 1980

It's 1980, and Dong-ho, identified only as "the boy," is standing outside the Provincial Office of Gwangju. It looks like it's about to rain, but the clouds have yet to break. Nearby, a young activist is talking about all the people shot and killed in protest today. Dong-ho, who has seen row after row of dead bodies brought to the Provincial Office for burial, listens closely. His middle brother has warned him to come home, telling him that the city center is not safe—but Dong-ho feels he cannot leave now, in the midst of all this violence.

Earlier that morning, Dong-ho asked how many coffins they would have to arrange today. It is Dong-ho's job to keep a record of who is in each coffin and to record which bodies have been memorialized and which have yet to receive a "group memorial service." Yesterday, Dong-ho had to record 28 bodies. Now, he is told to expect 30 coffins.

The rest of the older students working in the Provincial Office have gone to the group funeral, but Dong-ho stays behind. From a distance, he hears the funeral-goers sing the strains of the national anthem, and he starts to sing along. The word "splendid" in the anthem makes Dong-ho think of the hollyhocks in his family's backyard, and he closes his eyes to picture them more carefully. When he opens his eyes, the trees are blowing in the wind—but no rain has yet fallen.

Dong-ho hears the funeral-goers observe a moment of silence. He, too, is silent for a minute, before he heads into the gym where the coffins are being stored. The smell makes him nauseous, even though there is a scented **candle** placed by every body to try and mask the odor. The most mangled bodies are covered by sheets, though occasionally people will uncover the corpses in order to identify them.

Dong-ho is always startled, when he pulls back the cloth, by how quickly bodies compose. There is one corpse, a young woman's body, which particularly "stuns" him: there are stab wounds all down her face and breasts, and her toes, perfectly pedicured, have swollen to triple the normal size. Dong-ho lights a new set of candles, trying his best to ignore the stink.

From the very first moments of the story, the gruesome circumstances of the Gwangju uprising—the endless stream of bodies, the constant threat of violence—stand in contrast to Dong-ho's youth. Even as Dong-ho takes in this horror, then, he can only process it as the middle-school "boy" he is. For example, his thoughts about rain distract him from the protest messages, and he can't stop wondering whether he should listen to his mother's scolding.



Just as Dong-ho is swept up in the chaos of these protests, readers are dislocated, too, given little information about why these corpses are being killed or who Dong-ho is working for. But the steadily increasing number of coffins suggests that the situation is getting worse, not better.



Dong-ho is still pre-pubescent, but now, it becomes obvious that even the people in charge of this protest movement are not much older. Dong-ho's longing for his family's backyard speaks to his longing for normalcy, while the impending rain adds to the protestors' sense of foreboding.



Over and over again, the characters must contend with the physical realities of death—the scents and sights of decomposition loom large, and the speed with which human lives become smelly corpses is both an unignorable fact and an important symbol of the state's violation.



Though the scale of the violence has necessitated group funerals, certain details—like the precision of this girl's pedicured toes—help preserve individuality even in the face of mass death. It is also worth noting the gendered nature of this violence, a specific threat that will recur for several of the novel's female protestors.



Before he steps outside, Dong-ho wonders what happens to a person's soul when their body dies: "mightn't the person's soul also be there by the body's side," he thinks, "looking down at its own face?" But then the smell comes back, and he decides there are no souls here, only "silenced corpses."

The first time Dong-ho came into contact with these bodies, they were still being stored in the Provincial Office, having not yet been moved to the gym. He had wandered into the Office and seen two young women there, drenched in sweat with their faces masked. Dong-ho explained that he had come to see a friend, yet when he looked at the line of unidentified bodies, Dong-ho was not able to find his loved one. The two young women suggested that the friend might still be alive, but Dong-ho was certain his friend had been killed, having heard from one of his neighbors.

One of the women, still in a school uniform, cleaned the body of a young man whose throat has been sliced with a bayonet. As she worked, she invited Dong-ho to join them, helping them deal with the crush of corpses. "From that day on," Dong-ho reflects, "you became part of the team."

The two women, Dong-ho learns, are Seon-ju and Eun-sook. Eun-sook is in her final year of high school, while Seon-ju works in a dressmaker's shop. Both had rushed to the Provincial Office to give blood to the wounded. But when they realized how confused and understaffed the Office was, they stepped in, helping to clean, categorize, and cover the corpses.

Dong-ho is only in his third year at middle school, and he is small for his age: he always sits in the front row of class, and puberty has not yet lowered his voice. Jin-su, the quiet, "almost feminine" leader of the Provincial Office volunteers, was initially surprised that a boy so young as Dong-ho would want to work here. But Dong-ho persisted, keeping a ledger of all of the bodies and helping mourning families identify their loved ones.

Throughout the narrative, the idea of the soul will be a subject of much thought and debate. On the one hand, the concept of a human soul allows survivors to feel their loved ones' presence even after they have been killed. On the other hand, the sheer brutality of the Gwangju massacre makes it difficult for Dong-ho to see anything more than the shot down, "silenced" bodies in front of him.



Initially, this makeshift moratorium Dong-ho is working in might have seemed somewhat official to readers. Now, however, it is evident just how slapdash these efforts are. With a sudden onslaught of killing and no infrastructure to handle the dead bodies, young people like Dong-ho and these two women in masks have had to come together to fill in the bureaucratic gaps. The friend Dong-ho is talking about will later be revealed to be Jeong-dae.



The use of second-person narration here ("you became") is important: it both places readers in Dong-ho's shoes and reframes the whole story as something that is being written to Dong-ho, as if the book is a letter (or even a eulogy) rather than a novel.



Though Dong-ho, Eun-sook, and Seon-ju are all teenagers, they are almost instinctively committed to helping each other, forming a joint barrier against the atrocities going on outside the Provincial Office doors.



Again, the narration juxtaposes Dong-ho's bravery and competence—he immediately leaps into action in this urban graveyard of sorts—with his youthful innocence. The mention of Jin-su's femininity, which will later shape his treatment at the hands of soldiers, again foreshadows the gendered expression of so much of the soldiers' cruelty.



Everyone splits the labor at the Provincial Office: Eun-sook and Seon-ju work to clean the bodies, Dong-ho covers them, and Jin-su creates the posters that inform the people of Gwangju who has died. The thing that confuses Dong-ho is his fellow activists' insistence on singing the national anthem. He is also mystified by the fact that the Taegukgi, or the national flag, is placed over the coffins. Dong-ho wonders why his fellow activists sing the national anthem in mourning when the state is responsible for all this death.

In this important moment, Dong-ho struggles with what it means to be a part of a collective. On the one hand, the seamless unit he creates with Eun-sook, Seon-ju, and Jin-su feels comforting and empowering, allowing them to (literally) tend to atrocities none of them could handle on their own. But this kind of groupthink can also be dangerous, as Dong-ho sees in the images of state violence that the national anthem evokes in him.



When Dong-ho poses this question to Eun-sook, she assures him that the soldiers are only acting on orders from their superiors and that they do not truly represent the nation. But as Dong-ho listens to people sing the anthem over and over again, he cannot overcome this dissidence, nor does he feel any closer to understanding “what the nation really was.”

Even as dictator Chun Doo-hwan and his soldiers enact immeasurable pain, Eun-sook and others (like Yeong-chae in a later chapter) maintain their love for South Korea. Rather than framing protest as dissident, then, the novel suggests that activism can be intensely patriotic—that “the nation” can be made and remade by the kinds of crowds within it.



When the Provincial Office started filling up with bodies, Dong-ho tried to move some of the corpses outside. When Jin-su saw this, he immediately worried about what would happen if it rained. Jin-su then got a group of men to take the bodies in a truck, moving them from the Office into the gym. Dong-ho remembers watching the truck arrive as he played with the branches of a “still-adolescent gingko tree.”

Dong-ho's instinct to move the corpses outside reflects both his eagerness to help and his naivety. The “still-adolescent” gingko tree, which will be cut down by the story's end, also symbolizes Dong-ho's own youthful state.



Soon after Jin-su transported the bodies to the gym, some grieving families began decorating each coffin with a framed picture; some also started using empty Fanta bottles as vases and candleholders. It was Dong-ho who came up with the idea of getting **candles** for every corpse, and Jin-su—like always—was able to immediately turn this thought into a reality.

It is important to note how practical and competent Jin-su is in the early days of the Gwangju uprising; though his time in jail will eventually leave him broken and dissolute, this first encounter with an almost impossibly in-control Jin-su makes that contrast especially stark. The fact that Dong-ho chooses candles as a way to honor and cope with death will take on great symbolic importance as the narrative progresses.



Now, they have gotten into a routine. In the morning, people bring in bodies who have passed away while being treated at the hospital. In the evening, people bring in bodies of people the soldiers have shot in the suburbs. Seon-ju and Eun-sook frequently have to stuff spilling intestines back inside stomachs, which causes Seon-ju to have nosebleeds and Eun-sook to vomit. Dong-ho still manages the ledger, silently recording the bodies. As he does so, he reflects that dead look like they have gathered for a “convention.”

The extent of the killing necessitates that Dong-ho, Eun-sook, and Seon-ju take an almost business-like approach to this horrific violence: they develop shifts and routines, replacing the traditions of a graveyard with those of a corporate “convention.” Yet even as the protestors try to mentally adjust to this death, the physical reality is so gruesome that organizers like Eun-sook and Seon-ju struggle with it on an almost cellular level.



Now, Dong-ho wonders why the rain still has yet to come. One of the protestors is listing demands: the government must release their dead, free those in prison, and acknowledge the truth about what has happened in Gwangju. The crowd that cheers these protests is getting smaller every day. Dong-ho thinks back to the first day after the soldiers withdrew, when 100,000 people gathered to sing the national anthem. But recently, there have been rumors that soldiers are going to come back, and everyone is getting increasingly fearful of leaving their homes.

The protestor's mention of bloodshed makes Dong-ho's chest tighten. He thinks back to his grandmother's death a few months ago. In life, his grandmother had been quiet and kind, sneaking Dong-ho pastries from her pantry. Her death was similarly quiet—"something seemed to flutter up from her face," and then she was gone. Dong-ho finds himself wondering where this fluttering thing could have gone. He doesn't believe in heaven or hell, or in the scary stories of ghosts he hears at school.

Suddenly, it starts to pour, and the cold and drenching rain makes Dong-ho think of the tears of souls. As the trees bend to the rain, Dong-ho thinks about what his life might look like if "that other world continued"—it would be time for midterms now. But last week, when Dong-ho went out to buy a study book, he instead watched as a couple, seemingly newlyweds, were murdered on their way to church. Even in the memory, Dong-ho cannot fully reconstruct how it happened. The violence feels like "too much to process."

Eun-sook returns to the gym, pulling Dong-ho out of his reverie. She gives him a sponge cake and yogurt, explaining that the aunties at the protest were handing some food out. As Dong-ho eats, ravenous, Eun-sook tries to persuade him to return home and get some rest. Dong-ho feels self-conscious: he hasn't showered in a while, and he knows he stinks of sweat and the stench of the corpses.

Eun-sook announces that the soldiers are coming back tonight: "if you go home," she warns, "stay there." As Dong-ho looks at her, with her furrowed brow and her hollowed eyes, he wonders where the "fluttering" soul resides while people are still alive. Dong-ho wolfs down another yogurt.

Since something terrible has already happened in Gwangju, it is likely that these events are located somewhere in the middle of the 5:18 uprising. The 5:18 uprising (also known as the Gwangju massacre) denotes a series of protests against dictator Chun Doo-hwan, who had recently seized office. The protests stretched through the month of May, and each protest was met with more violence than the last, leading to hundreds of civilian deaths. The fact that the rain still has yet to come perhaps signals, then, just how much violence still lies ahead.



The question of afterlife—and particularly the question of whether people have tangible souls—will become a major one in the novel, especially as those who survive Dong-ho mourn the young boy. It is especially worth noting the language Dong-ho here uses to conceptualize what such a soul might look like. To Dong-ho, the soul is bird-like and "flutter[ing]": it is present, delicate, and not quite tangible.



In the "other world" Dong-ho craves, his anxieties and preoccupations would be radically different: he could be stressed about tests rather than about senseless, seemingly random violence. Yet even as his world changes, Dong-ho's youthful curiosity persists as he wonders about why it rains and tries to snag some extra studying time.



Dong-ho's hunger for the sweet sponge cake and yogurt speaks both to his childish preferences and to the fact that he is still very much a growing boy. Dong-ho's sudden self-consciousness about how he might smell further gets at his pubescent mindset.



The characters in the novel all know what physical, embodied death looks like. But the hollowness in Eun-sook's eyes also suggests that trauma can mutate the soul (again described as "fluttering") in more subtle ways, squashing and contorting the life force of those still living.



A while later, Seon-ju arrives, this time bringing gimhap for Dong-ho. Though he eats with gusto, when Seon-ju starts asking about Dong-ho's dead friend, he finds that the rice gets caught in his throat. Seon-ju, who was also there on that day of sudden violence, hypothesizes that soldiers buried Dong-ho's friend. Dong-ho studies Seon-ju's composed face and wonders if she will stay behind in the Provincial Office to wait for death. Seon-ju says that she's tired and then goes to take a nap.

When the rice of the gimhap gets caught in Dong-ho's throat, it demonstrates how grief for a dead loved one can disrupt the most basic processes of life, like chewing or swallowing. Yet even as Dong-ho faces Jeong-dae's horrible absence, he continues to feel hungry, so he must continue to eat. This conflict—between grief about those whose bodies no longer work and the omnipresent survival instinct—will become a source of frustration for many of the other characters.



Dong-ho's mother is convinced that his friend Jeong-dae is at the hospital, not here. Dong-ho's mother and brothers—the oldest brother at school in Seoul, the middle brother trying to pass his exams—are terrified that Dong-ho is dealing with these corpses. They are worried Dong-ho will be killed. Yesterday, they tried to persuade him to come home. But Dong-ho refuses, insisting no one will kill him for taking notes.

Dong-ho's insistence on staying at the Office despite his parents' warnings poses a crucial question: is Dong-ho being impossibly brave or impossibly naïve? And even though this section of the narrative stays close in Dong-ho's perspective, even he does not seem clear about how truly cognizant he is of the risks he is taking.



The rain has stopped. Dong-ho reflects on the lie he told Eun-sook and Seon-ju—it wasn't a neighbor who had seen Jeong-dae die. Dong-ho thinks back to that day: he and Jeong-dae are at a protest together when soldiers, hidden, start firing at protestors from the rooftops. Dong-ho takes cover, but Jeong-dae is toppled. Seeing his friend on the ground, wearing the same blue **trackpants** that he himself has on, Dong-ho tries to rush to him. But before he can do so, the soldiers shoot another mourner, so Dong-ho stays where he is.

The fact that Dong-ho initially lied about the circumstances of Jeong-dae's death suggests that he feels some measure of guilt; after all, he survived this first round of shooting while his equally young friend did not. This guilt then becomes an important driving force for Dong-ho's decision to risk his life at the Office. The image of trackpants—which is part of the middle-school boys' gym uniforms—will come to symbolize both Dong-ho's youth and the almost brotherly friendship he shared with Jeong-dae.



It takes 10 minutes for the shooting to stop long enough for Dong-ho and others to make their escape. While they walk, the soldiers methodically pick up and disposed of the bodies. Keeping his eyes on the ground, Dong-ho hurries home, heading straight to the terrace in the back of the house. It is all Dong-ho can do to keep himself together when Dong-ho's father asks for a back massage.

While Dong-ho is wracked with guilt merely for witnessing his friend's death, the soldiers actually doing the killing seem to feel no such remorse. Dong-ho's cheerful family life makes the reality of the violence seem even more shocking.



At last, Dong-ho is able to escape to his room, where he curls up in the fetal position. Dong-ho can't picture anything other than Jeong-dae's face, and his **trackpants** in the dirt. Like Dong-ho, Jeong-dae is unusually small, so much so that his sister Jeong-mi is always trying to sneak extra milk to him. Jeong-dae hates studying, preferring to goof off. But despite his rebelliousness, Jeong-dae is loving. Once, he stole a blackboard eraser from school simply because it reminded his sister of an April Fool's prank long ago.

First, despite his bravery in the protests, Jeong-dae is actually a very normal boy: he is physically small and filled with jokes and impractical plans. Second, Dong-ho's commitment to remembering Jeong-dae's life beyond the circumstances of its tragic end help preserve his friend's life beyond the bounds of his physical existence.



Dong-ho gets up and goes to the annex of his hanok (a traditional style of Korean home), where Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi have been staying. He recalls the day before, when Jeong-dae was in a panic, trying to locate Jeong-mi. Dong-ho knows that if Jeong-mi is still alive, she will fault Dong-ho for not doing more to protect her brother. Though she is quiet, Jeong-mi is known for her stubbornness, too.

Jeong-mi had lived in Dong-ho's house for a year, but the two had never had a real conversation. Jeong-mi was always getting back late from the textile factory where she worked, too tired to do anything other than ask for Dong-ho's help starting a fire. One night, however, she had surprised Dong-ho by asking him for his old first-year textbooks. Jeong-mi admitted that she hoped to one day be able to go back to school, so she was studying for the high school entrance exam.

Dong-ho was skeptical that Jeong-mi could keep her studies a secret, but he lent her his book anyway. That night, and many nights to follow, Dong-ho had imagined kissing Jeong-mi and holding her tightly. In the coming mornings, Dong-ho would crawl to the door just to hear her washing her face.

Back in the present, another truckload of bodies pulls up the gym. Jin-su is firm that the soldiers are coming back tonight—and that by 6:00 p.m., all the bereaved will need to leave in order to ensure their safety. As Jin-su goes to break the news to the grieving families, Dong-ho hears some of them arguing, vowing that they would rather die than leave their children.

Privately, Dong-ho wonders if the young girl's body in the corner could be Jeong-mi. He has no evidence for this, but he wants to be able to prove that Jeong-mi is safe. Dong-ho knows that if the roles were reversed, Jeong-mi would have gone to every hospital in order to track Jeong-dae down, just as she did every time they had a fight. Even though Jeong-mi was laughably stubborn, she was also tender. At night, Dong-ho would hear "low laughter and shared sighs" coming from the annex, as argument between the siblings gave way to warmth.

Back at the gym, Dong-ho is making posters of the missing when his mother arrives. In a panic, Dong-ho's mother grabs his wrist roughly, begging him to come home. Dong-ho jerks away but promises that he will return to his house at six o'clock, when the gym closes. Dong-ho's mother makes him promise to be home for dinner.

Just as Dong-ho (irrationally) blames himself for Jeong-dae's death, Jeong-dae reacts to his panic over Jeong-mi's disappearance by feeling guilty. The fact that both Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi have disappeared (and been killed) in such a short time again testifies to the ever-faster pace of the violence.



Jeong-mi's life, too, exemplifies the gap between an old reality—in which the adolescent pitfalls of school and studying were all-consuming—and this new, terrifying one. Jeong-mi's commitment to education even in the face of logistical hurdles also suggests that school and the written language of textbooks help to provide an escape from the brutality of daily life in Gwangju.



Dong-ho's crush on Jeong-mi forces readers to imagine a counternarrative—one in which Dong-ho gets to come of age normally, navigating his newfound desire for his friend's sister rather than searching for her dead body. But what could be a classic coming-of-age story is in fact a much darker tale.



Jin-su's warning is clear: when the soldiers come back, anyone found tending to the dead is in grave danger of being killed. The fact that Dong-ho hears this warning and decides to remain by the bodies anyway suggests his amazing sense of courage (and naivety).



Even though Dong-ho knows that Jeong-mi is probably dead, he still feels a sense of responsibility to her. This collectivist mindset, which many of the characters share, perhaps also explains why Eun-sook, Seon-ju, and Dong-ho are willing to endanger themselves to care for strangers' corpses—any one of these bodies could be the body of someone they love and feel they owe something to.



This dialogue is in some ways a familiar conversation for a child to have with his parent; indeed, the phrase "be home for dinner" borders on cliché. But here, the stakes of Dong-ho returning home for dinner are literally life and death.



An hour later, an old man enters the gym, struggling to walk. He explains to Dong-ho that he has come from far in the mountains, having heard that his son and granddaughter might have been killed in the recent violence. As the families pack up their supplies and prepare to evacuate, Dong-ho leads this old man through the bodies. Though he inspects each one, the old man does not recognize his relatives.

Dong-ho hates this part of his job. He has nightmares about pulling back the cotton sheets to reveal decomposing faces. Sometimes, he feels as if he, too, is being stabbed by a “phantom bayonet.” When Dong-ho pulls up a sheet on a body in the corner, he can tell, without words, that this is the old man’s granddaughter. Dong-ho wonders again how long souls stay by their bodies. He thinks that, in the moment of killing, he would have run away from anyone—his mother or father or brothers. “There will be no forgiveness,” he decides. “Least of all for me.”

CHAPTER 2: THE BOY’S FRIEND, 1980

The recently murdered Jeong-dae explains that all of the dead bodies, including his own, have been thrown together on a pile. Jeong-dae’s soul is still attached to his body, so he can see what is happening to it: he is loaded into a military truck with others and jolted along. People used to say they would meet again in the afterlife, but Jeong-dae thinks that sentiment is now foolish and untrue. He does not sense any other souls here.

Jeong-dae watches as the blood flows out of his own face. The truck drives up a hillside, eventually stopping in front of an iron gate. Several military sentries unlock the truck and help drag the bodies inside into a clearing, Jeong-dae’s included. As the sentries stack the bodies on top of one another, Jeong-dae realizes that his body is second from the bottom, though he doesn’t feel the pressure now.

As it gets dark, Jeong-dae’s soul climbs to the top of the pile, hoping to catch a glimpse of the moon. Slowly, he becomes aware of the presence of other souls, though none of these spirits have any language with which to identify or communicate with one another. Eventually, after coming into contact for a moment, the other souls all flit away.

Nowhere does the narrative suggest that this man might be Jeong-mi and Jeong-dae’s grandfather—but once more, the loss of a brother and sister makes Dong-ho associate the dead strangers with his own closest friends.



The image of the “phantom bayonet,” which will recur for the writer at the end of the novel, suggests that physical violence wounds not only those directly hurt but also those who bear witness to others’ injuries. Dong-ho’s feeling that there will be no “forgiveness” again speaks to his sense of collective responsibility—he feels that if he was not able to save Jeong-dae, he cannot save anyone, and therefore he himself does not deserve to be saved.



In Dong-ho’s section, the young boy wondered what kind of soul still “flutters” on earth when a person’s physical body ceases to function. Now, Jeong-dae’s portion of the narrative answers that question though a stylistic choice: author Han has Jeong-dae write from beyond the grave, suggesting that human personality persists even beyond physical violence and bodily collapse.



By allowing Jeong-dae’s soul to separate from his body, the novel posits that each individual person is much more than the sum of their physical parts. On a formal level, then, this section of the novel also demonstrates the power of language to change the narrative around violence, death, and loss.



Though Jeong-dae is able, through a literary trick, to communicate with readers, he cannot talk to the other murdered souls around him. Even as the novel points to the power of language, then, it also highlights the limits of verbal communication.



The night continues, blurring into day as the grasshoppers chirp. Jeong-dae wants to believe that something is watching over him, but he doesn't think anyone is. Instead, he thinks of Dong-ho, who'd been by his side until Jeong-dae "collapsed like a rag doll[.]"

Now, it is sunny, and the flies have begun to feed on the rotting corpses. Jeong-dae notices the ants crawling on his fingers. Jeong-dae tries to move, but he realizes that he is bound to this one spot. Jeong-dae also sees that he can sense who is still alive and who is dead—Dong-ho, he knows, is still alive. But Jeong-mi is dead, and the pain of that knowledge is so great that Jeong-dae screams, even without a tongue or voice.

Jeong-dae now loses all sense of himself and his identity. He begins to feel rage, wondering why he and Jeong-mi have been so brutally murdered. Jeong-dae is desperate to find his sister, but he does not know how to locate her. Jeong-dae takes comfort in the idea that once his soul is removed from his body, he will be able to track down those who killed him.

The truck arrives again at the same time as yesterday, bringing new bodies. With a start, Jeong-dae realizes the intense stench his pile of corpses has begun to give off. Jeong-dae senses new souls in this new crop of bodies, and he floats over to them. He feels jealous of a body that has been tended to, the wounds dressed. For the first time, Jeong-dae feels true hatred for his body.

Jeong-dae wants to escape this present moment through dreams or memories. He thinks back to a time he stole a blackboard eraser from school and then left it on the windowsill to please Jeong-mi. Then, Jeong-dae recalls falling asleep next to his sister: how she would laugh as she drifted off, and how she would always touch his face before rolling over for the night. To keep himself sane, Jeong-dae focuses on every sensory detail of that night—the smell of Jeong-mi's lotion, the sight of the hollyhocks outside, and the sensation of his face, which he knows Jeong-mi "had loved."

Though the cosmology that Jeong-dae and Dong-ho seem to share makes room for a soul and a very tangible afterlife, neither Jeong-dae nor Dong-ho believes in a god-like figure (perhaps because the amount of violence they have witnessed has made them lose faith).



This striking passage contrasts the truth of bodily vulnerability with the expansiveness of human feeling. On the one hand, Jeong-dae cannot stop his body from stinking or from falling prey to ants. But on the other hand, Jeong-dae finds a way to scream even without his tongue and vocal cords, suggesting that bodily ruin cannot tamper with emotional pain.



Now, the body becomes a nuisance: instead of helping Jeong-dae accomplish his goals, his body only gets in the way of him finding his sister or his murderers. The idea that violence turns the body into a liability will recur many times throughout the narrative.



The loathing Jeong-dae feels for the form that once nourished him is a tragedy in and of itself. But Jeong-dae's desire for someone to tend to and clean his wounds is also a testament to the importance of Dong-ho's work back at the gym—because of Dong-ho's commitment to caring for the corpses, many souls will be spared the sense of isolation Jeong-dae now feels.



This childhood memory of the blackboard eraser shows both the depth of care Jeong-dae had for his sister and the youthful innocence they both shared. Jeong-dae's reflections also bring into focus the importance of mutual care: whether it is someone (likely Dong-ho's mother) continuing to water the hollyhock or Jeong-mi holding her brother's face, living beings depend on one another to feel "loved" and to survive.



Jeong-dae is desperate for more memories. He recalls summer nights he spent riding his bike and traveling to some nearby rice paddies. He tries to remember the taste of sweet potato, even when it burned his tongue. Then, Jeong-dae's thoughts dissolve into poetry as his knowledge of the bleeding wound in his side replace his memories of wanting to be taller. All he can do to calm himself is think about finding the soldiers who killed him and demanding to know why.

For the first time, Jeong-dae explicitly contrasts the revivifying effect of memory—even of the most quotidian events—with the destruction of violence (as seen in his bleeding wound). In other words, memory gives wholeness and permanence to the very people and places the soldiers have worked so hard to harm. Jeong-dae's desire to be taller is an especially poignant reminder of his youth—not so long ago, he wanted his body to be bigger rather than for his corporeal form to vanish entirely.



Time passes, undifferentiated by anything except the arrival of more and more bodies. Some of the bodies are completely mangled, while others are almost fully intact. One time, Jeong-dae sees a couple of bodies with the faces painted entirely white, probably to erase the dead peoples' identities. He wonders if all these bodies were once protestors, packed onto the street alongside him. He recalls the moment of his death—Dong-ho was panicking, but Jeong-dae, though also afraid, just kept on singing the national anthem.

Jeong-dae can feel no strength or solidarity with the giant pile or bodies that surrounds him now. But when he was still alive, the crowd was a source of energy—perhaps dangerously so, as Jeong-dae struggled to retain a rational sense of caution in the swell of the national anthem.



The bodies at the bottom of the pile are the first to rot, and Jeong-dae's own face becomes unrecognizable, the swelling erasing his "clear edges." At the same time, however, Jeong-dae is getting better at recognizing the souls around him, differentiating between them even if he cannot identify each soul as a specific person. With more time, Jeong-dae wonders if the souls could figure out a way to understand each other, even in the absence of language.

In large groups, the novel will frequently suggest, individuals lose sight of their own personal values and limitations, blending entirely into the ethos of the whole. And here, the idea that Jeong-dae is losing his "clear edges" suggests that even in death, a large gathering blurs the boundaries between each unique, separate, person.



Unfortunately, one rainy day, the soldiers arrive earlier than usual. They throw more bodies onto the towers of corpses, gagging at the stench, and then cover all of the piles in petrol. The "fluttering" souls crowd together as the soldiers sparked their lighters. As Jeong-dae watches, the soldiers step back and set the entire clearing aflame.

The use of the word "fluttering" here, spoken by a dead soul himself, affirms all of Dong-ho's suspicions about peoples' bird-like souls.



As soon as the piles of bodies catch fire, Jeong-dae realizes that the only thing keeping his soul tied to this clearing is his physical body. As "the viscera hisse[s] and boil[s]," Jeong-dae's soul slides over to two soldiers, taking in their dilated, frightened pupils and young faces. Jeong-dae wonders where to go. He wants to visit Jeong-mi, but he has no idea where her soul might be—though he hopes she is still waiting in the annex room they used to share.

In this fascinating passage, Jeong-dae realizes that he might have more in common with the soldiers than he initially thought. Just as he got swept up in a crowd, behaving with bravery and abandon he might not have had on his own, the youthful soldiers have lost similar track of themselves. The mention of the "hiss[ing]" and "boil[ing]" body parts here again forces readers to contend with the gruesome realities of mass death.



Instead, Jeong-mi decides to go visit “you,” meaning Dong-ho—he is certain Dong-ho will still be asleep in the house they used to share. But before Jeong-dae can make the journey, he hears a terrifying scream. Jeong-dae looks at the sky, where the flares from guns are lighting up the night. Somehow, he knows Dong-ho has been killed. Though he wants to find Dong-ho’s soul and guide him through his new existence, Jeong-dae now thinks that task is impossibly daunting.

On a plot level, this moment is crucial: Dong-ho’s death at the hands of the soldiers returning to Gwangju will shape every chapter to come. But this is also an important scene on a formal level—by referring to Dong-ho as “you” as he dies, Jeong-dae makes it clear that he is telling this story to and for Dong-ho, telegraphing his care and (pre-emptively) preserving his friend’s memory.



CHAPTER 3: THE EDITOR, 1985

It’s mid-November, five years after the violence at Gwangju. Today, Kim Eun-sook, now an editor at a local publishing house, was slapped seven times, so brutally that her cheek bruised and she lost her hearing in one ear. She decides to head home rather than going to work, vowing to spend one day forgetting each slap, so that in a week this violence will be only a memory.

Five years later, the worst of the Gwangju massacre has subsided—but Chun Doo-hwan remains in power, and the threat of violence is no less omnipresent (as those seven slaps make clear). The fact that Eun-sook works in a publishing house is also worth noting—language and storytelling, in the background in the young boys’ narratives, will come even more into focus here.



When she gets home, Eun-sook lies down for 20 minutes. Then she gets up, washes her face, brushes her teeth, and crawls back into bed. The phone is ringing, but she feels that she cannot answer and give an explanation. It is getting dark outside by the time Eun-sook sits up in bed. She wonders how she will “forget the first slap,” and she recalls waiting quietly for the first slaps to be over, not running away.

Eun-sook’s quiet, isolated coping mechanisms suggests that she is still deeply traumatized by the horrors she witnessed in 1980. While Jeong-dae did his best to remember delicious foods and jokes with his sister, it now becomes evident that violence is the one thing worth forgetting. But ironically, as Eun-sook’s question demonstrates, violence is one of the hardest things to forget.



The man who interrogated her, calling her a “bitch” and hitting her so hard it drew blood, had “thin lips” and looked “utterly ordinary.” The interrogator struck Eun-sook as a middle manager, even as he violently demanded to know where the translator (“that bastard”) was.

It seems that Eun-sook was slapped because she worked with a translator wanted by the state. First, then, interrogator’s violence shows just how dangerous Chun’s government understands language to be. More than that, though, the “utterly ordinary” appearance of the interrogator suggests that anyone is capable of brutality (just as Dong-ho’s life and death shows that anyone is capable of great bravery).



Eun-sook met with the translator two weeks ago, on the first really cold day of fall. They shared tea and a pastry as the translator went through the manuscript proofs and edited them. The translator was courteous and seemed timid, even though Eun-sook knew he was a wanted criminal. When she asked him how to contact him to give him his royalties, he responded vaguely, promising only to be in touch.

The translator is clearly engaged in bringing some earth-shaking texts to the South Korean people, but he goes about this daring business with an air of ease and normalcy. In many ways, then, the translator is the converse of the interrogator: he seems “ordinary,” but he is in fact a radical, selfless figure.



In the interrogation room two weeks later, as the slaps continued, Eun-sook thought back to the fountain in Gwangju. Then, at 18, she had seen the glittering jets of water as an attack. Eun-sook had called the Provincial Office in tears, wondering how the fountain—which had been turned off since the beginning of the uprising—could now be turned on again, as if nothing had changed. Years later, as the first slap came, Eun-sook couldn't believe it: "surely he's not going to hit me," she'd thought, until the interrogator hit her with so much force her neck seemed to snap.

In the present, Eun-sook is back at the office. Noticing her face, Eun-sook's publisher offers to take her out to barbecue. Eun-sook wonders if his friendliness might be guilt—is he the one who turned her in to the authorities? After all, the publisher had gone to the police station only minutes before she had, even speaking with the same interrogator.

Eun-sook declines the publisher's offer of barbecue—she finds the sight of meat cooking revolting. But the publisher convinces her to let him take her out to lunch. As they finish their meal, the publisher offers to go to the censor's office in Eun-sook's place tomorrow. Eun-sook knows the publisher feels guilty, even though he had probably only stuck to the facts ("Kim Eun-sook is the editor in charge"). She tries to smile to reassure him, but her bruise makes the smile look grotesque.

After work, Eun-sook walks home. Now, she thinks about the second slap—why did the interrogator use his left hand when he used his right hand for everything else? She feels intense nausea. Again, Eun-sook recalls the fact that she did not move when she was hit.

The next day, Eun-sook arrives at the censor's office. As always, someone searches her bag. "At such moments," Eun-sook reflects, "a part of one's self must be temporarily detached from the whole." The security guard examines her residence card, her tube of Vaseline, and her sanitary pads.

The spurting fountains at the Provincial Office, an important image throughout Eun-sook's narrative, are so painful in part because they suggest that people are trying to move on from the 5:18 losses. In turning on the fountain jets, Eun-sook thinks, the Gwangju city government is glossing over the memory of all people lost in the massacre. By pairing this memory with the interrogator's slaps, Eun-sook seems to suggest that forgetting the murdered protests is itself a violent act, almost akin to being hit.



As Eun-sook's boss, the publisher likely could have taken responsibility for her work with the translator—but he did not, and Eun-sook was then slapped seven times. The publisher's guilt here has a faint echo of the guilt Dong-ho feels about Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi, as if by not taking the bullet himself he was partially responsible for their deaths.



Like the narrator will say in a later chapter, Eun-sook's hatred of meat is likely linked to the human carnage she witnessed during the 5:18 uprising. The publisher here appears as a character perched between bravery and cowardice: he wants to get the controversial literature to press, but he is not quite courageous enough to face the consequences himself.



Eun-sook now tries to make sense of something senseless—how could she ever give logic to something so outside the bounds of normal human language and contact?



Already, several characters have lost sight of their individual selves in the heat of a crowd. But what Eun-sook experiences here is different: the shame and discomfort of state surveillance causes her to dissociate, "detach[ing]" from her "self."



Eun-sook recalls another such search that happened soon after she had arrived at Seoul for college. She had been in the cafeteria when plainclothes policemen rushed in, beating students and throwing furniture. Without thinking, Eun-sook picked up a flier on the floor. The flier's big block lettering read: "DOWN WITH THE BUTCHER CHUN DOO-HWAN." But as soon as her hand closed around the leaflet, the police pulled her hair, dragging her from her chair.

Now, in the censor's office, Eun-sook stares up at the framed picture of Chun Doo-hwan. She wonders how a face can conceal so much evil and brutality. Eun-sook waits as the censors, hard at work, make their way through a variety of texts. Finally her name is called, though by the way the desk manager asks her to sign, it is clear that something unusual has happened with Eun-sook's text.

Eun-sook goes to the censor's office all the time, and usually a dozen words have been crossed out or rearranged. But this time, she feels as if "the pages have been burned." More than half the text has been crossed out. Sometimes, as if going through the text sentence by sentence is too exhausting, the censors use **an ink roller** to black out an entire page. Eun-sook knows that the plays can never be published like this.

Unbidden, some of the sentences from the text's introduction pop into Eun-sook's mind ("after you were lost to us, all our hours declined into evening"). As her cheekbone throbs, Eun-sook wonders again how the fountain in Gwangju could ever be on again. "What could we possibly be celebrating?" she muses.

Now, it is four days since the slaps, so Eun-sook is devoted to forgetting the fourth slap. It is a Saturday, but instead of making weekend plans with friends or a date, Eun-sook will just finish work (she gets out early today), make dinner, and then go to sleep. She does not have any friends from university that she could see, even if she wanted to.

Before the work day is done, Eun-sook's Mr. Seo, the producer from the theater, arrives, interrupting Eun-sook's thoughts. Having heard that the censors **ink-rolled** much of the text, Mr. Seo has come to see for himself. Eun-sook presents him with the proofs. As Mr. Seo sees the damage, Eun-sook begins to cry. She keeps apologizing, though Mr. Seo assures her she has nothing to apologize for. Eun-sook almost spills her coffee on the proof, and Mr. Seo snaps it up—"as though it still contains something."

Here, Eun-sook's history in the past five years comes clear. After protesting in Gwangju as a high school student, she got caught up in similar protest movements in college. Even when she tries to avoid protest, therefore, it seems as if activism is baked into Eun-sook's existence. It is also worth noticing that the lettering on the flier is, to the state police, a threat—language always has real power, so language always must be quashed.



The fact that all texts must pass through the censor's office speaks to Chun's government's fear of the written word. Whether it is criminalizing translators, brutalizing editors, or crossing out sentences in books, Chun's administration is determined to erase all of the language that questions it.



Just as it felt violent to Eun-sook when the fountains in Gwangju were turned back on, the act of censorship carries its own brutality, "burn[ing]" the pages (and making their editor feel scorched, too). Even as pens and ink are tools of power and protest in the right hands, then, when state officials wield writing implements, they become dangerous weapons.



The glimpses of text that Eun-sook reflects on now suggests that the play in question is meant to honor and parallel the 5:18 massacre. Thus, erasing this narrative, like turning on the jets in the fountains, almost further violates those already killed.



Many of the consequences of the Gwangju massacre were embodied and immediate. But Eun-sook's loneliness is no doubt a result of the fear and torment she was subjected to as a student activist, both in high school and at university.



Once more, the state censor's ink roller is a weapon, working metaphorically to cause pain but also bringing Eun-sook to very literal tears. Mr. Seo's determination to save the play hints at the desperation these protestors feel to communicate their message, even against the state's widespread, efficient silencing.



On Sunday, Eun-sook plans to sleep in, but as always, she is wide awake by 4:00 a.m. It is time to do laundry, so she throws her clothes into the machine and tries to go back to sleep. Now, she wants to forget the fifth slap, which drew blood to the surface of her skin. As the washing machine finishes and Eun-sook hangs her clothes up to dry, she wishes these simple household chores would take up more of her time.

In her youth, people often complimented Eun-sook for being cute. But after the Gwangju uprising, no one praises Eun-sook's looks anymore. And she herself just wants to speed up the aging process, hoping life will come to an end soon. As Eun-sook makes breakfast, she resents that she still feels hungry, even after all the horror and grief she has witnessed.

After the violence in Gwangju, Eun-sook's mother begged her to move on. So Eun-sook went to university—but even at university, there were always policemen around, beating student protestors and smashing windows. Eun-sook suffered from terrible nightmares after the violence in Gwangju, and it was almost a relief when returned home to tend to her ailing father. Soon, Eun-sook dropped out of school and took a job at the publishing house. She was grateful not only to spare her family the financial burden but to know that now, she could not join student protests—and so she would not be killed.

The day the army returned to Gwangju, Eun-sook had not “set her mind on surviving.” She remembers that fateful evening: after dinner, she sneaks out from her house, returning to the Provincial Office. When she gets there, the women are arguing about whether they should carry guns. Seon-ju, always quiet, says very little, though she flashes Eun-sook a smile as she argued that the women should be armed.

Jin-su arrives, asking three of the women to stay behind as guards. Though all of the women initially want to stay as a show of solidarity, Jin-su convinces them that it would look bad for the resistance if too many were killed. To her surprise, Eun-sook finds that her time around dead bodies has made her more afraid of death: “she didn't want her last breath to be from a gaping mouth.”

On the one hand, Eun-sook is desperate to find anything that could block out the memory of these slaps. But on the other hand, the sheer work of survival—doing laundry, hanging clothes—feels frustratingly pointless to Eun-sook, who often struggles with the idea that she survives when so many of her loved ones were murdered.



Even in the first days of the Gwangju uprising, Dong-ho noticed that Eun-sook looked to be “hollow[ing]” out, as if her soul was disappearing in front of him; now, that process seems complete. In her frustration with eating, Eun-sook is struggling with what could be called survivor's guilt—how can she continue to eat when the dead cannot?



Frequently, the narrative points out that people behave differently on their own than they do when in crowds or mobs. But it is still worth noting that Eun-sook seems almost biologically, inevitably drawn to protest: she moves from activism in Gwangju as a high schooler to sit-ins in college to publishing work that represents a subtler form of protest. In other words, while many might have moments of protest under the right circumstances, only rare people like Eun-sook do so consistently.



Even with years of reflection, Eun-sook struggles to make sense of her motivations and thought processes on the night that Dong-ho died. Whether or not she chose to “survive” is an open question, just as Eun-sook and others will agonize over whether Dong-ho knew the risks he was taking.



Jin-su insists that women should be treated with a kind of chivalry, even though (as Seon-ju's chapter will reveal) some of the worst violence in this era of Korean history was against women. Interestingly, Eun-sook's fear of death is not as much about the absence of life as it is about the gruesome bodily decomposition she has witnessed. Eun-sook understands just how fragile bodies are, and that makes her all the more afraid of damaging her own.



Seon-ju stays behind, as does Dong-ho (“you”), wearing his gym sweater and his blue **trackpants**. Eun-sook tries to convince the other soldiers to send him home, explaining that he is only in middle school. But Dong-ho remains. (“Had she ever had such a thing as a soul,” Eun-sook reflects in the present, “that was the moment of its shattering.”)

Eun-sook leaves, hiding herself in a nearby hospital with a friend whose aunt is a patient. Sheets are hanging from all the windows, and it is pitch black, but all the patients and nurses fear that they might be killed. Each time the friend’s aunt asks a question, the friend can only reply, “I don’t know, Aunty.” No one can tell how much time has passed.

Finally, a voice over the loudspeaker announces that the army is returning. The voice implores all citizens to come in front of the Provincial Office, explaining that “we have resolved to fight to the end.” Eun-sook stays put, listening to the sounds of combat boots and shooting and trucks. In the present, Eun-sook’s thoughts shoot back to Dong-ho. Eun-sook remembers that Dong-ho’s eyelids quivered, “because you were afraid. Because you wanted to live.”

Now, it is six days since the slaps, and the publisher has just received an invitation to the premiere of the censored play. Eun-sook wonders how staging the play will be possible, since so much of it has been removed. But when the published book arrives, Eun-sook is surprised to see that only a few paragraphs have been excised. And instead of the wanted translator’s name on the cover, Eun-sook sees that the translation has been credited to the publisher’s cousin in America. The publisher seems proud, though Eun-sook notices the fear in his eyes.

A few hours later, Eun-sook is alone in the office. She finds a book about the psychology of crowds, which focuses on protest movements and wars throughout history. The book argues that large groups lead to more nobility and barbarism, “through that magnification which occurs naturally in crowds.” In the next paragraph, the censor has drawn his **pen** over two sentences: “what is humanity? What do we have to do to keep humanity as one thing and not another?”

There are three important ideas in this passage. First, Eun-sook addresses Dong-ho as “you,” making it clear that this section, too, is written as a kind of letter to the murdered little boy. Second, Eun-sook mentions her “soul”—but it has lost the lightness and “fluttering” flexibility that Dong-ho saw when his grandmother died. Third, for Dong-ho, the loose-fitting trackpants were a symbol for his beloved friend Jeong-dae; for Eun-sook they represent Dong-ho in a similar way.



Eun-sook and her unnamed friend are both young, but in this moment of confusion, no one can really “know” anything. This moment thus inverts the usual pattern of life: many of Gwangju’s young people end up taking care of the old instead of the other way around.



Returning to the Provincial Office would meet certain death, so the fact that Eun-sook stays put amounts to a decision—she is choosing to survive. But though Dong-ho similarly longs to survive (“you wanted to live,” Eun-sook recalls), he does not choose safety when the time comes. Instead, his childlike inability to act rationally on his fear is one of the reasons his death continues to strike Eun-sook as the greatest tragedy of all.



Dong-ho, like the others killed that night at the Provincial Office, was only given one chance to be brave—which is part of the tragedy of that loss. But because the publisher continues to live and work, he is able to make up for his earlier cowardice at the interrogator’s office by ignoring the censors now. The publisher also puts himself at risk by lying about who did the translation (presumably so that the state will not immediately condemn the plays for their association with the wanted translator).



This vital excerpt gives theoretical backing to the groupthink Eun-sook and the other organizers have long intuited: being in a crowd almost always “magnifies” each individual’s kind or cruel traits. The fact that the censors have crossed out the question about humanity makes the violent symbolism of the censor’s pen literal—here, the state is literally crossing out “humanity” as an idea.



Eun-sook has “no faith” in humanity anymore. She thinks back to the day after the soldiers slaughtered so many people in Gwangju, when they went door-to-door asking parents if their children had been involved in the demonstrations. Eventually, Eun-sook learned from her mother that all of the corpses were being deposited in a single mass grave. The fountain was still dry that day. But now, no matter how many times Eun-sook calls the Provincial Office, no one will turn the fountain off.

Eun-sook’s loss of faith seems to stem from two things. First, the methodical, uncaring nature of the violence made her lose hope in people. Then, the fact that everyone in Gwangju seemed to move on from the atrocity (as seen by the jetting streams of the fountain) made her give up on humanity forever.



Instead of trying to forget the last two slaps, Eun-sook goes to see the censored play. The play begins almost like a dance, as a woman and a man, both dressed in mourning clothes, pass each other silently. Eun-sook looks around, taking in the journalists and other artists in the packed audience. She also notices plain-clothed policemen, and she fears that the policemen will beat Mr. Seo and the actors in the play will be beaten when they see that they have defied the censors.

If these policemen could beat Mr. Seo, then Eun-sook is surely in danger as well. But staying true to the collectivist mindset she has had since high school, Eun-sook fears more for the others around her than she seems to fear for herself.



But rather than say the censored lines, the actors only move their lips—“after you died I could not hold a funeral,” the actress mouths silently, “and so my life became a funeral.” After a few moments, the lights come up on the audience, and Eun-sook sees a little boy wearing **trackpants**, surrounded by older actors who are shrieking and moaning. The little boy, who is carrying a skeleton, reminds Eun-sook of Dong-ho.

If erasure of language is one of Chun Doo-hwan’s central ways of maintaining power, then the persistence these actors show—making the shapes of censored words even if they do not say their sounds—is one of the most powerful forms of protest. In staging the play this way, therefore, Mr. Seo is demonstrating that even in the absence of language, South Koreans will find ways to make their dissent known.



Gradually, all the actors stop moving. Finally, there’s just one old woman frozen onstage. The little boy jumps on her back, “like the spirit of someone dead.” Funeral odes, written on scraps of paper, begin to fall from the ceiling. Eun-sook is weeping, her memories of Dong-ho fresh, but she does not look away. Instead, she “stares fiercely at the boy’s face, at the movement of his silenced lips.”

This little boy wearing the trackpants that Eun-sook and others so associate with Dong-ho seems as though he is Dong-ho’s soul (or “spirit”) made tangible. Though this image is deeply painful for Eun-sook, it is also galvanizing—Eun-sook knows this is a pain she cannot look away from. And in seeing Dong-ho’s “silence” reenacted, Eun-sook feels newly “fierce.”



CHAPTER 4: THE PRISONER, 1990

A university professor is interviewing an unnamed narrator. The narrator recalls being tortured with a black Monami Biro, an otherwise ordinary **pen** that became an instrument of tremendous pain. Over and over again, the interrogator would jam the pen into the narrator’s left hand, leaving his right hand undamaged so he could write his confession. By the end of the torture, the narrator’s left hand was a pulp of “raw meat.”

In Eun-sook’s chapter, pens and ink were symbolic instruments of violence. But here, Chun Doo-hwan’s repressive state itself makes that symbolism literal, as the fancy pen mutilates the narrator’s hand. It is also important to note whom this narrator is speaking to: for the first time, the novel’s words are being directed not to Dong-ho but to this mysterious professor.



When the narrator was first arrested, none of the prisoners dared to ask where they were or even to speak. Each interrogation began with some physical torture, confirming to the narrator “that my life had been taken out of my own hands, and the only thing I was permitted to do now was to experience pain.” The interrogators would ask questions calmly, but the answers the prisoners gave them were never sufficient. And when the interrogators sent the narrator back to his cell, they made him sit completely straight against the wall as guards shouted at him and the other prisoners, denying them food and water. The men weren’t even allowed to fall asleep.

Three times a day, the guards fed the prisoners. The narrator was paired with Kim Jin-su, who ate little. As they shared their small portions, the narrator felt Kim Jin-su’s eyes follow him, devoid of life. Now, Jin-su has recently died, having taken his own life. As the narrator speaks with the professor, he wonders why he was able to survive while Jin-su was not.

The narrator becomes frustrated, wondering why the professor would want to dredge up all his most painful memories with this interview. Besides, Jin-su’s experiences were not identical to the narrator’s. Because of Jin-su’s somewhat feminine features, he was subjected to whole other forms of torture, as when the guards would unleash ants to nibble on his genitals.

In 1980, during the uprising, Jin-su was still only a freshman in college. The narrator did not know Jin-su well, so he was surprised when Jin-su decided to stay behind that night the soldiers came back into town. The narrator recalls that night: together, he and Jin-su make wills, preparing for death. Even after Jin-su is ordered to escort the women home, he comes back, ready to face the army as bravely as he could.

But as the army approaches, Jin-su suddenly finds himself overcome with tiredness. He lays down, and soon the rest of the protestors join him, as if Jin-su’s sleepiness is contagious. At one point in his nap, the narrator wakes to see Dong-ho crawling in beside him. Jin-su is scolding Dong-ho, telling him to go home. When Dong-ho refuses, Jin-su only make him promise that when the soldiers come, he will surrender right away.

Though the narrator is speaking in 1990, he seems to reflect on torture that took place some time ago. Poignantly, just as Jeong-dae felt that his body was holding him back, the narrator now feels that the sensory “experience” of bodily pain has nullified his “life”—his inner thoughts and feelings and dreams. In other words, by forcing him to be aware of his bodily vulnerability, the state torturers have made the narrator lose his sense of interior self.



Now, the narrator’s place in the story becomes clear: this is the same Jin-su who supervised Dong-ho, and the narrator seems to have been arrested for his own participation in the Gwangju uprising. The narrator’s guilt about his survival mimics Eun-sook’s, as does his complicated relationship with his own natural metabolic processes and cravings for food.



Like Eun-sook, the narrator wants to forget the worst of the violence—even though it seems that the trauma he endured has seared every detail of that violence into his brain. The fact that Jin-su received extra harsh treatment because of his “feminine” traits once more suggests that the violence under Chun was often gendered, enacting the regime’s regressive vision of male dominance.



Jin-su’s clarity of conscience, decency to others, and sense of bravery is clear in nearly every anecdote about him—at least before the state’s brutal torture. Though the narrator and Jin-su were not personally close, the bonds of a shared cause nevertheless made them ready to die together.



This strange sleepiness could be read in many ways: as young people’s lack of awareness about the situation they would soon face, as a kind of preparing for death and afterlife, or even simply as exhaustion with the state’s endless brutality. It is crucial to note that Jin-su does not want Dong-ho to be there, risking his life in this way—and that, hoping to protect Dong-ho’s life, Jin-su gives him the specific directions on how to surrender that will later lead to Dong-ho’s death.



The narrator was 22 at the time, one of the oldest members of the resistance. Even though the narrator knew rationally that the army wildly outnumbered them, he could not help feeling the force of “conscience, the most terrifying thing in the world.” Similarly, even as a spokesman for the student militia told journalists that everyone was prepared to die, most of the students themselves felt more hope that they would survive than fear that they would be killed.

When the narrator first started protesting, he was amazed by the sense of strength and unity he found in crowds, singing the national anthem as if he could feel “the sublime enormity of a single heart.” But when the bullets and tanks came, that unity was shattered. As the narrator faced the fallout the next day, the lines outside the hospital and the looted guns, he wanted only to regain his feeling in the crowd—“the miracle of stepping outside the shell of our own selves.”

The narrator and Jin-su were old enough to make this decision for themselves, but Dong-ho was not. He was more concerned with sponge cake than with this grave choice. The narrator doesn’t know exactly what happened when the soldiers arrived. He only knows that no one in the resistance fired their guns (because they did not know how to) and that Jin-su made Dong-ho promise to “look for a way to live.”

Later, the narrator found out that the army had been given 800,000 bullets—enough to shoot every person in Gwangju twice. The narrator knows that the people in the student militia who were killed that night spared many more others from a similar fate. Those who were not killed were jailed, punished according to whether they were found holding guns.

Those who were not holding guns were released in batches. But those whom the soldiers had found holding guns experienced even more extreme forms of torture: “hairpin torture” and a horrific procedure known as the “roast chicken.” Looking back, the narrator begins to realize the purpose of such tactics—the army was trying to make these men feel ridiculous, as if their resistance was only ever a joke. The narrator thinks back to his hungry, horrible days in prison.

The narrator’s relative maturity perhaps explains why he can give such a balanced, straightforward recounting (unlike Dong-ho and Jeong-dae’s more piecemeal, emotionally driven stories). But even at 22, the narrator was still unable to entirely accept his situation, feeling hope instead of a much more realistic awareness of the danger he was in.



The narrator likely has not read Eun-sook’s book about crowd psychology, but here, he describes what it feels like to live such a phenomenon. In the crowd of protestors at Gwangju, the narrator was able to give and gain strength from everyone around him, feeling almost as if their blood was coursing through his own veins—as if they shared “a single heart.” And in a way that felt almost “mirac[ulous],” the narrator was able to leave behind the fragile “shell” of his individual selfhood (with its cowardice and caution) to find something more “sublime” and powerful in the crowd.



Dong-ho may have been insistent with his mother that he wanted to stay at the Provincial Office, but the narrator is now the second character to affirm that Dong-ho was not ready to die. And even though Jin-su encourages Dong-ho to protect himself, Dong-ho could not—the logistics and stakes of the situation would be almost impossible to understand as a young boy.



The scale of Chun Doo-hwan’s violence is now revealed to be even larger than previous characters have understood. The narrator’s insistence that the student militia’s resistance saved others, while it might be true to some extent, also reflects his anxiety that all of the losses did not mean anything.



The logic behind the narrator’s desire to bring meaning to his co-protestors’ deaths now becomes clear: he is trying to counteract the state’s torture, which reduces everyone to their painful, embodied instincts. Only by continually dwelling on the causes he and his co-protestors fought for can people like the narrator salvage themselves from the state’s violence.



The youngest prisoner, a quiet, brave boy with a stutter, is named Kim Yeong-chae. Every so often, Jin-su talks to Yeong-Chae; he tells Yeong-Chae he does not need to use honorifics with him, as they are around the same age and come from the same region. As the narrator gets to know Yeong-Chae, he learns that the boy lost his cousin in a protest. But though Yeong-Chae tells the story of his cousin's death with dry eyes, when Jin-su asks his favorite foods—sponge cake and Sprite—he bursts into tears. Yeong-Chae is being tortured, too.

Yeong-chae should immediately remind readers of Dong-ho: both are young, quiet boys, and both swerve between steely bravery and childlike yearnings for sweet treats. Yeong-chae's breakdown at the mention of sponge cake is particularly poignant—such simple pleasures now feel so alien in this world of torture and starvation. Like Dong-ho, Yeong-chae was not old enough to know exactly what he was choosing—namely, a life that could never hold small pleasures again—when he stood in those crowds of protestors.



In the present, the narrator tells the professor that every time he sweats in summer, he remembers how he felt in this era of torture: that he was no more than sticky flesh and pus. In those times, as his shoulders or toes were forced apart, the narrator would do anything to end the pain; he remembers shouting “for God’s sake stop, I did wrong.”

In the crowd at the Provincial Office, the narrator felt principled. But since the interrogations, the narrator is too aware of his own fragility—of the sweat and pus inside of him—to care about those principles or about anything other than ending the torturers’ escalating pain.



A few months later, the narrator recalls, the soldiers convened a makeshift court. Thirty men were sentenced at a time, as guards forced them to bow their heads and patrolled the seats of the courtroom with their guns. The prisoners were told that if they spoke or even lifted their heads, they would be immediately killed in their seats. But on the day of the narrator’s group trial, Yeong-Chae began to sing the national anthem. The rest of the men soon joined in, singing softly but clearly. To everyone’s surprise, the soldiers let their prisoners finish the song.

Yeong-chae's decision to sing the national anthem reflects both the unique bravery of youth and his belief, widely shared in the novel, that protesting is patriotic. After months of torturing individual prisoners, this show of unity perhaps intimidates the soldiers.



The narrator explains that he was given a nine-year sentence, and Jin-su was given seven years. But these sentences didn’t really mean anything: the men were released in batches, as if even the soldiers knew the charges were absurd. Two years after being released, the narrator sees Jin-su again. But though time has passed, neither man has been able to accomplish anything—not go back to school, move out, or even date. The memory of the interrogation room is still too fresh.

Though little was known about the narrator's life before his torture, readers have seen time and again that Jin-su used to be a highly competent person. But the torture has left its mark, and though Jin-su and the narrator are no longer in physical pain, the emotional wounds block them from ever forging normal lives (a seemingly common phenomenon for survivors of the Gwangju uprising).



In the present, both men have become reliant on alcohol to get any rest, so they split a bottle of soju until neither of them are really conscious. Then, this becomes a ritual: for years, Jin-su and the narrator meet to lament their loneliness and inability to work, as they swap alcohol or painkillers and try their best to forget. Neither man can even fathom the idea of taking revenge—they are too exhausted. Every so often, Jin-su laughs at the fact that they thought guns—which none of them had ever fired—could protect them.

Memories of life before and after violence can provide comfort, but—as was true for Eun-sook and Jeong-dae as well—violence is something at once necessary and impossible to forget. Jin-su's comment that none of the protestors could actually fire their guns again points to these young peoples' innocence and to their utter naivety about what they might have to face.



In 1989, the narrator finally starts working as a taxi driver. One rainy night, Jin-su approaches the narrator after his taxi shift. Jin-su looks even more devastated than usual, and as the narrator welcomes Jin-su into his apartment, he feels real fear. Finally, Jin-su explains that there was a trial, and Yeong-chae has been sentenced to life in a psychiatric hospital. Apparently, Yeong-Chae tried to kill someone after trying to kill himself six times. The narrator can't bear to hear this story, so he pours himself a glass of soju, excuses himself, and goes to bed.

As he told this story, Jin-su wondered aloud what a soul was, desperate to know what Yeong-chae lost when the torturers abused him. "It was only when we were shattered that we proved we had souls," Jin-su reflected. After the torture, "what we really were was humans made of glass."

Shortly after that visit, the narrator reads about Jin-su's death in the newspaper. There are not enough coffin-bearers at Jin-su's funeral, so the narrator volunteers, though he leaves before the service is over. The narrator never read Jin-su's suicide note, nor did he look at the photo that accompanied the note, which showed several young children dead in a straight line. Now, in the story's present, the narrator is livid that the professor is asking him about these things, even if it is for the purpose of his scholarly, "psychological autopsy."

On that day in Gwangju, the narrator and Jin-su lay with their faces down while the soldiers taunted them ("I was in Vietnam, you sons of bitches"). Eventually, five of the youngest members of the resistance came down, including Dong-ho. None of these boys had any weapons, and they all walked out in a straight line with their arms up. In the present, the narrator tells the professor that the kids were lying in a straight line because they were shot in a straight line—"with both arms in the air, just like we'd told them to."

The narrator reflects that "some memories never heal." Instead, these rare memories are so painful that everything else fades away. The narrator wonders if "the experience of cruelty" is the only thing every human being shares: the idea that "each one of us is capable of being reduced to an insect, a ravening beast, a lump of meat." Once, a soldier in Busan revealed to the narrator that the army incentivized extra brutality with cash prizes.

Time moves much faster in this section than in other chapters, giving readers a sense of the blurry, monotonous way that the narrator and Jin-su experience life. Jin-su's deep pain at Yeong-chae's hospitalization, even years after they knew each other, once more reflects the lifelong connections that this month of activism in 1980 created. And losing Yeong-chae, whom he met in his youth, likely reminds Jin-su of Dong-ho's death.



In this vital passage, Jin-su echoes the idea that humans really do have souls. But while Jeong-dae explores how souls can persist even after death, Jin-su seems aware that souls can vanish even in life if someone experiences significant trauma. And when the strength of a soul vanishes, all that is left is a vulnerable, physical body, fragile as though "made of glass."



The fact that Jin-su leaves a photo of murdered children with his suicide note directly links his death to the 5:18 massacre—indicating that the violence of the past is hurting for victims long after 1980. The phrase "psychological autopsy" will reverberate for other characters, as the professor expands his interviews to as many survivors as he can reach.



For the soldiers, this kind of violence is almost a game—some of them have even gone from war to war, finding power and pleasure in repeated group brutality. More importantly, this revelation shows why Jin-su blames himself so directly for Dong-ho's death—he told Dong-ho to stand in a school-like formation, emphasizing his youth, and Dong-ho wound up dead in that very line.



The narrator has long known that human beings can be reduced to "raw" flesh, their bodies in so much pain that they begin to feel like nothing but "a lump of meat." But here, he reflects that just as anyone can become the sum of their fragile body parts, anyone can also be like that soldier, pushed by the swirl of the crowd toward acts of unimaginable "cruelty."



Indeed, the narrator believes that many of the soldiers who came to Gwangju were remembering moments in the Korean or Vietnam wars where violence was met with a “handsome reward.” The narrator feels that every member of the human race is capable of such cruelty—including people like himself and the professor. Every day, the narrator looks at the scar on his hand from **the pen**. “So tell me professor,” the narrator asks, “what answers do you have for me? You, a human being just like me.”

The narrator's utter distrust of the world is painfully evident here. After all, why should he trust the professor's commitment to telling his story with written words when the state's terrifying pen still scars his hands? And how can he rely on “a human being” like the professor—or even more terrifyingly, himself—when he has seen how powerless or brutal all humans can become? All it takes is torture, being interrogated, or even just standing in a crowd for humans to step outside of themselves.



CHAPTER 5: THE FACTORY GIRL, 2002

It is 2002, but Seon-ju can't stop thinking about years ago, when she would spend all her time with Seong-hee and their other labor union friends. Now, reflecting on that time—when they would talk about the moon and lounge around on rooftops—only makes Seong-hee sad. In the present day, in her office, Seon-ju checks her email and smokes a cigarette. Everything feels difficult, as if she is underwater.

More than 20 years have now passed since the Gwangju uprising, but like the narrator and Eun-sook, Seon-ju still feels almost physical pain from her memories. Interestingly, though, Seon-ju did not begin protesting during the 5:18 uprising, as the others did. Her activism started years earlier, with Seong-hee's group of young female labor organizers.



In a flashback that she labels as “Up Rising,” Seon-ju remembers the sound of footsteps. She recalls waking up in the middle of the night and hearing a child. Back in the present, Seon-ju thinks about how she ended up in this office. For years, she had worked with Seong-hee in the labor rights organization. Ten years ago, however, she got a call from a man named Yoon. Yoon was hoping to do a “psychological autopsy” on Seon-ju's old student militia unit, and he wanted her help.

In these poetic, experimental, “Up Rising” sections, Seon-ju reflects on the vague outline of a young boy, one who seems to resemble Dong-ho (or at least an abstracted version of him). The translation of these sections as “Up Rising” is particularly telling: the words testify both to the force of memories when they “rise” to the surface and to Seon-ju's life of protesting (rising up). In linking these two ideas through language, the “Up Rising” sections suggest that memory is its own form of protest. On a plot level, it is important to note that Yoon is almost certainly the same professor interviewing the unnamed narrator for his aforementioned “psychological autopsy.”



At first, Seon-ju declined. But after talking to Yoon more recently, she learned that seven of the ten surviving members of the militia had agreed to a series of interviews. When Seon-ju still expressed hesitation, Yoon merely sent her his dissertation and a set of tapes, hoping she could at least record her voice even if she couldn't bear a sit-down interview. Seon-ju has another flash of the “Up Rising” memory, imagining footsteps and dripping water.

Language was once a tool to hurt Seon-ju and her activist friends, but Yoon's project—in which he gets survivors to bear witness to the truth of what happened in Gwangju—hopes to reclaim language as a tool of healing and strength. The footsteps and dripping water might allude, however vaguely, to Dong-ho's morning routine back at his family's hanok.



Though Seon-ju works all day categorizing and transcribing various audio and video recordings, the cassette tapes Yoon has sent her to record on still feel overwhelming. Seon-ju's work focuses on environmental disasters, namely deaths and disease caused by radioactivity. She wonders how Yoon will be able to stand the stories of bayonets and drill bits and cudgels. Already, the first interview described in his dissertation involves torture, as the unnamed interviewee describes being taken captive and brutalized in a nearby university.

The first interviewee survived. In his interview, he explains that though he had never prayed before, his prayers to be released from torture were answered relatively quickly. But he cannot forget the faces of others who were not so lucky, like a pair of college girls gunned down on their campus. These faces haunt his nightmares, just as the dead bodies Seon-ju used to clean and sort at the Gwangju Provincial Office haunt her memories.

That night, Seon-ju wakes up long before dawn, disturbed by what she has read. She is almost 42, but she has only lived with a man once, and that only lasted one year. After all, living alone means Seon-ju can wake up whenever she needs to without fear of disturbing another person.

A few days later, Seon-ju is staying late at work when her boss, Park Yeong-ho drops by. Park is cramming, hoping to shut down a nearby nuclear reactor. He wonders why Seon-ju has cranked up the heat in the office so high. All of the other employees are younger than Seon-ju, and they speak to her with a kind of quiet deference. Only Park ever questions her or teases her, calling her "a human search engine."

When Park notices that Seon-ju is using the Dictaphone, smoking cigarettes, and drinking coffee, he assumes she is just cramming to meet a deadline, too. Park apologizes for the long hours and meager pay, confessing that he and the other employees are curious about what motivates Seon-ju. Park wonders about Seon-ju's relationship with Seong-hee, who is "the stuff of legend" to him and other, younger labor organizers. Seon-ju feels too tired to explain her relationship to Seong-hee, or to tell Park about all that she has seen.

Like Eun-sook, Seon-ju has continued her life of activism long after the events at Gwangju. But though Seon-ju now works as an environmental activist, studying the long-lasting effects of radiation, she knows that the realities and impacts of the Gwangju violence are even harder to talk about.



As Eun-sook experienced when she went to college, it's mostly students who hold protests against Chun Doo-hwan. And while students are, in some ways, the most courageous members of society, they're also the most vulnerable and unprepared. Also of note here is that, as with Eun-sook, the details of corpse decomposition linger in Seon-ju's mind long after any specific bodies have been buried.



Seon-ju's hesitancy at sharing space with another person—not to mention physical or emotional intimacy—gestures toward the sexual violence she will later acknowledge having suffered.



Like Eun-sook, Seon-ju spends much of her time alone, desperate to fill the hours to avoid thinking about painful memories. Clearly, her "human search engine" approach to her environmentalist job is one more way Seon-ju has found to distract herself from what happened all those years ago.



Now, Seon-ju's past work as a labor organizer starts to come into focus. Though she and Seong-hee were both schoolgirls when they began protesting the major factories, they ended up leading a national movement. Even two decades later, Seong-hee remains an important model for progressive activists like Park. But though the stories of such protests seem enviable after the fact, in reality they were more complicated—not just because Seon-ju had to witness great carnage, but also because her relationship with Seong-hee does not seem to have survived these activist actions.



The “Up Rising” memory comes again, as Seon-ju reflects on the ways she is different from Seong-hee. While Seong-hee believes in a god of some kind, Seon-ju struggles to pray. “I forgive no one,” she vows, “and no one forgives me.”

Back in the present, Seon-ju pretends to go home when Park leaves the office. But secretly, she turns around, planning to stay in the office so she can record the tapes for Yoon. Seon-ju has recently learned from the newspapers that Seong-hee is in the hospital. She calls her old friend for the first time in years, and the two talk, only briefly. For her entire life, except for the two years when she was in prison, Seon-ju has buried herself in her work. It feels easier and safer to be solitary. But now, Seon-ju feels a deep need to connect with Seong-hee. For some reason she can’t quite explain, Seon-ju believes that she must record the tapes for Yoon before she can visit Seong-hee in person.

Seon-ju thinks back to the factory labor she did as a teenager, which was so physically punishing and exhausting that she had to take pills to stay awake. Back then, the guards would search her every night, lingering on her private parts. There were no weekends, and Seon-ju was always getting sick from the factory fumes. Women only made half of the men’s already-low pay. No wonder that Seon-ju found solace in Seong-hee’s labor rallies, which helped factory workers insist that “we are noble.”

When Seong-hee had organized enough laborers to go on strike, she and the other young women formed a human wall in front of the factory. As policemen and strike-breakers approached, Seong-hee instructed the women to take off their clothes—young women’s bodies were sacred, so the activists were sure they would be safe if they were naked. But to everyone’s shock, the police still attacked, dragging the naked girls to the ground and beating them with cudgels. Seon-ju was brutalized so much that her intestines ruptured.

After Seon-ju healed, she decided to return home to Gwangju rather than continue to fight with the other factory workers. She was now blacklisted from most factory jobs, so she had to get a job at a dressmaker’s shop. The pay was even worse now, but Seon-ju found comfort from writing back and forth with Seong-hee, taking her time to write in *hanja* (traditional Chinese) characters as Seong-hee had taught her.

Seon-ju’s words here almost exactly echo Dong-ho’s anxiety that he will never be “forgiven” for letting Jeong-dae die. It is perhaps not a coincidence, then, that Seon-ju has this thought soon after the Dong-ho-centric “Up Rising” poem recurs.



Despite their closeness before and during the labor protests, it is now evident that Seon-ju and Seong-hee are estranged from each other. Moreover, the fact that Seon-ju feels the need to record her testimony for the professor before seeing Seong-hee suggests that their estrangement had something to do with how the two women remembered and discussed their activist history differently.



As Seon-ju thinks about her entry into protest, she takes a remarkably intersectional lens. Rather than seeing her conflict with the South Korean government as purely one of citizens vs. their state, Seon-ju sees how class and gender also impact the power structure she is fighting against. And to those marginalized both as women and as working-class factory employees, it’s no wonder that Seong-hee’s declaration of “we are noble” felt so radical.



Even as Chun Doo-hwan and his predecessor Park Chung-hee seem to advocate for traditional gender roles, they also disrespect and violate their country’s most longstanding ideas about women’s bodies and purity. It is also worth noting that all of the events Seon-ju reflects on here occurred before the protests at Gwangju. Unlike Dong-ho, Seon-ju knew what she was getting into when she stayed at the Provincial Office that night—she had already lived through a version of the state’s violence.



Traditionally, hanja characters would have been used in fancier, upper-class writing. But by teaching themselves to use hanja even without formal education, Seon-ju and Seong-hee find another way to use language as protest, challenging the rigid class divides of their society.



After three years, Seon-ju finally worked her way up to being a machinist in the dress shop. But as soon as she got this new job, Seon-ju was devastated to learn that a young factory worker had died in the riots, slitting her own wrists in protest. Quickly, Seon-ju begins to link the violence she experienced at her factory to similar incidences in Busan and Masan. She knows that the person responsible for all of this violence is President Park Chung-hee.

That October, Park Chung-hee was assassinated, and soon after, Chun Doo-hwan rose to power as the next president. Rather than lessening the violence, Chun Doo-hwan had even more frightening plans than his predecessor. Seon-ju became glued to newspapers, trying to understand what would happen next. One day, walking along the street, she saw a bus full of young factory girls. They were chanting protest slogans and holding a sign which read “END MARTIAL LAW. GUARANTEE LABOR RIGHTS.”

Feeling entranced by the chants, Seon-ju followed the bus all the way to the Gwangju Provincial Office. Though the protests in Gwangju had begun with university students, now, the square in the front of Office was filled with people of all ages. At the front of the protest were the bodies of two young people whom soldiers had gunned down.

In the present, as Seon-ju approaches a hospital, time seems to blur together. Seon-ju can still hear the girls’ protest song in her head, “carrying down through the years.” Seon-ju enters the hospital while she recalls the words “we are noble,” chanted over and over again. Seon-ju climbs to the roof of the hospital, then jumps off. But rather than dying, Seon-ju revives, only to repeat the process again—this is a recurring nightmare. Unfortunately, being awake is not much better. “Memories are waiting,” Seon-ju knows. “What they call forth cannot strictly be called nightmares.”

Seon-ju once felt proud that she was able to repress her memories—she was angry with Yoon for wanting to dig up her recollections of the past. In fact, her entire falling-out with Seong-hee hinged on this disagreement. Ten years ago, Seong-hee encouraged Seon-ju to make her story public, and Seon-ju was outraged. Now and always, Seon-ju feels that she is failing Seong-hee. For a moment, Seon-ju remembers the man who had been her husband for eight months, his kind eyes and his worried insistence that she sometimes scared him.

Many of the younger characters (from Dong-ho to Yeong-chaе to Jeong-dae) seem to have fallen into the protests almost by accident. But Seon-ju has a more expansive, historical way of thinking, as she links her own experience as a factory worker to state violence happening all over the nation.



Park Chung-hee was assassinated in 1979, and Chun Doo-hwan began to slowly accrue power over the next year, so Seon-ju is likely recalling the early months of 1980, just before the 5:18 uprising. In both the words of the newspaper and the block letters of this protest sign, language is a critical tool for gathering young people into a strong, vocal, crowd of protestors.



Though violence was common in the factory riots, flat-out murder was still unusual. In other words, at this point in Chun Doo-hwan’s rise to power, death was not yet normalized—and Seon-ju, like the rest of Gwangju, is still able to fully take in the tragedy and shock of each loss.



For Jeong-dae, memories were usually comforting; for the narrator, they were almost impossible to bear. Seon-ju locates herself in the middle of these two figures, finding strength in the recollections of the “we are noble” chant even as she hides from reflecting on the “nightmares” she once lived through.



The narrator gave his testimony 12 years before Seon-ju considered doing so, suggesting that the professor Yoon has been at this project for more than a decade. If testimony and language were always a big part of Seong-hee’s testimony, it makes sense that she would be hard on Seon-ju for refusing to share her story with the professor. Lastly, Seon-ju’s memories of her husband further hint toward her self-isolation in the years after the uprising.



In the present, Seon-ju is at the hospital—in reality now instead of in her dreams. As Seon-ju waits for the doctor to arrive, she thinks back to her youth in Gwangju, to a friend named Jeong-mi who had wanted to be a doctor. Seon-ju knew Jeong-mi would never realize this—the factory would destroy her body before she even got time to study for the middle school exams.

Over and over again, characters in the novel have lamented that the violence at Gwangju cut short the lives of young people. But here, Seon-ju adds a new dimension to that narrative, pointing out that the unfair conditions they were protesting were also destroying dreams (like Jeong-mi's aspiration to be a doctor).



Seon-ju washes her face, brushes her teeth, and applies lotion. She wonders what Seong-hee will look like—it has been 10 years since they last saw each other, and Seong-hee sounded so different on the phone. Seon-ju recalls moments in their protest days when she and Seong-hee, not caring about propriety, slept curled next to each other for comfort and warmth. Seon-ju remembers that Seong-hee always snored loudly.

Seon-ju's friendship with Seong-hee signals just how close protestors could become over the course of their activism. Specifically, the image of the two women curled up next to each other echoes the image of Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi, snuggling for warmth in the annex of the hanok.



Still in the hospital waiting room, Seon-ju falls into a restless sleep. She dreams of the phrases from Yoon's emails: "testimony. Meaning. Memory. For the future." Seon-ju knows Yoon wants her to "bear witness" to her own suffering, but how is she supposed to bear witness to the rifle that was pushed up her vagina, to the various abuse so intimate it left her forever unable to have children? How can Seon-ju explain that the violence was horrific enough that she became afraid of touch and affection, even friendship?

There have been several suggestions that much of the soldiers' violence was gendered, but only now do readers learn the full extent of the sexual assault Seon-ju had to suffer. The scale of this trauma helps make sense of Seon-ju's hesitancy to give "testimony," even though she knows words can be a vital form of "memory" and a way to bear "witness." But no words could suffice to capture the degree of invasion and pain she suffered at the hands of these soldiers.



When Seon-ju wakes to the sound of a hospital patient moaning, she decides to leave. In the middle of the night, she crosses the damp grass and heads home. As she walks, she thinks again of the two college girls murdered on the grass. With horror, another moment of "Up Rising" comes to Seon-ju—in this moment, the footsteps are just outside her door, coming towards her.

Tragically, this passage makes clear just how much the violence has altered Seon-ju's experience of the world: even the simple, natural pleasure of grass makes her think of death. Though Seon-ju has yet to mention Dong-ho's name, footsteps will later become a signifier of the young boy's tangible presence (or soul) for his mother and the writer.



Seon-ju recalls driving around with the other female students, begging the residents of Gwangju to at least turn on their lights. The soldiers eventually apprehended them, arresting the various protestors. Because Seon-ju had a gun and was involved in labor rights organizing, they called her "Red Bitch," insisting that she was a spy from North Korea. The military police interrogated Seon-ju for so long that she could barely think.

The fact that most residents of Gwangju will not even turn on their lights reflects just how terrifying it could be to defy the soldiers. Upsettingly, the interrogators match Seon-ju's more global view of the protests, linking Seon-ju's straightforward call for labor rights to the tension of the Korean War 30 years earlier.



After several years, Seon-ju was able to track down Seong-hee, who had also been in prison. Both women have been gravely aged by their years of arrest and torture. When they reunited, Seong-hee told Seon-ju that Jeong-mi, after protesting and being blacklisted from the factory, had disappeared. Now, Seon-ju struggles to remember the contours of Jeong-mi's face; all she can think of is the phrase "I want to be a doctor."

When a young person dies, Seon-ju's memory of Jeong-mi seems to suggest, those who survive them mourn the innocent life lost. But they also mourn the person that young boy or girl had yet to become—maybe Jeong-mi would have been a doctor, or Jeong-dae would have been taller, or Dong-ho (as his mother will later speculate) would have been a poet.



In the present, the "Up Rising" memory comes again. Seon-ju recalls that she came back to Gwangju "to die." At first, the city looked similar, until she noticed the quiet in the streets, the bullet holes in the walls of the Provincial Office. But on a walk one day, Seon-ju noticed a picture of Dong-ho plastered onto a wall of a Catholic Center. She took down the picture as quickly as she could, walking fast to avoid the police's prying eyes. "You saved me, Dong-ho," Seon-ju thinks, "you made my blood seethe back to life."

Dong-ho's face is a galvanizing image for the activists who knew him, but the photo of this young boy becomes a call to protest even for those who were less personally involved. For Seon-ju, as for Eun-sook decades earlier, the memory of Dong-ho is energizing and even life-"saving." In remembering Dong-ho, Seon-ju suggests here, she remembers what she is fighting for, and therefore why she must survive to fight.



In the present, as Seon-ju continues her walk away from the hospital, she thinks back to Dong-ho asking why she and Eun-sook placed the Taegukgi over the dead bodies in the gym. Seon-ju does not remember Eun-sook's answer, but privately, she thinks it is because they were trying so hard to make the deaths mean something. Seon-ju feels that she can never return to this time again—to a time before she knew what torture felt like. When the "Up Rising" feelings come again, she realizes she might never know who the footsteps belong to.

Part of Chun Doo-hwan's success in quashing the uprisings was to make them feel pointless—but like the unnamed narrator, Seon-ju is committed to giving meaning to the activists' lives, both those that continue and those that have been cut short. Fascinatingly, Seon-ju does not assign the young footsteps to Dong-ho. It is possible that by viewing these footsteps as more universal, Seon-ju—always an organizer of giant groups—is placing her story in the context of the thousands of others like herself.



As she thinks of Dong-ho and Jin-su, Seon-ju reflects that she has "the capacity for neither bravery nor strength." She blames herself for leaving the factory after she was beaten, and she also blames herself for leaving Seong-hee's labor movement later in life to go work with this environmental group. Seon-ju knows that one day she will have to face danger head on, and she thinks back to that night on the roof when she was seventeen, eating peaches with her friends and staring at the moon.

Crowds of any size (from the protestors in front of the Provincial Office to the teenaged friend group on Seong-hee's roof) give "bravery" and "strength" to those who do not have it on their own. And so while Seon-ju cannot find the strength to think about Jin-su and Dong-ho when she is by herself, memories of being with her community give her the energy she needs to honor those two victims of the massacre.



With the hospital behind her, Seon-ju thinks the thought she has been avoiding: that she is responsible for Dong-ho's death. If she'd sent him home, begged for him to leave as they ate gimhap together, maybe he would not have stayed and lost his life. Seon-ju walks on, raising her head to the rain. As she walks, she thinks, "don't die. Just don't die."

Like Eun-sook, Jin-su, and later Dong-ho's mother, Seon-ju blames herself for the fact that Dong-ho stayed behind that fateful night. But rather than seeing this possibility as literally soul crushing, like Jeong-dae did, Seon-ju sees it as a responsibility to keep surviving. As she promises to stay alive and raises her head to the rain, Seon-ju seems newly committed to her causes, fighting for justice and leading out the life that Dong-ho didn't get to live.



CHAPTER 6: THE BOY'S MOTHER, 2010

It is the early 2000s, but Dong-ho's mother still thinks she sees her son. As she follows the little boy, trying to keep up with his fast pace, she has to admit that there are many differences between him and Dong-ho: for instance, they have different haircuts and different backpacks. But they have the same energetic walk, and the same small bodies that have not yet grown into their hand-me-down **trackpants**. "You'd come back to me this one time," Dong-ho's mother thinks, "and this dodderly old woman couldn't even catch you up."

After walking for hours behind the little boy, Dong-ho's mother feels nauseated, so she sits down on the ground to rest. She realizes that she has been walking through a construction site, and the dust is making her sick. From then on, every time construction happens, Dong-ho's mother stands in the streets, hoping to see that little boy, so like her son, walk by. She wishes she had called Dong-ho's name when she saw that little boy, and that he had just turned around so she could see his face.

At the same time, Dong-ho's mother knows this little boy can't be her son. After all, she buried Dong-ho herself. Once, she ate a handful of the grass on his grave just to feel closer to him. Dong-ho's mother cannot forget how pale Dong-ho was, his face ashen from losing so much blood. Nor she can forget how Dong-ho's middle brother vowed revenge. Years later, the middle son looks so much older than he should—his anger has aged him.

While Dong-ho's middle brother remains enraged, his older brother is friendly and bubbly, visiting Dong-ho's mother every so often to bring her food and cheer her up. The older brother looks just like Dong-ho. As a child, he would rush home from school, eager to play with the new baby or hold him on his lap.

During one visit, the older brother accused the middle brother of failing to save Dong-ho's life. In response, the middle brother howled in pain, violently dragging the older brother to the floor. When Dong-ho's mother saw this fight between her two adult sons, she could not find it in herself to break it up. Instead, she walked on into the kitchen, making pancakes and cooking meat for breakfast.

As Seon-ju and Jeong-dae have both seen, memory can bring purpose and comfort in times of distress. But now, 30 full years after Dong-ho's death, his mother learns just how unsatisfying memory can be. Her recollections of Dong-ho are so strong that she can overlook a different haircut and a more modern backpack just to pretend the boy in front of her is her son. But even as she chases the memory, represented by those too-big trackpants, she knows that she cannot ever "catch" her slain child.



Dong-ho's mother's desperation here echoes the ancient Greek story of Orpheus and Eurydice, one of the most important allegories for grief and memory in the literary canon. Also, like those glittering fountain jets Eun-sook complained about, the construction around Dong-ho's mother shows that life in Gwangju will inevitably move on from the massacre.



Dong-ho's mother's willingness to eat grass, like her willingness to chase this stranger boy, demonstrates how much mourning defies language and other traditional forms of logic or communication. In comparing the bloodless face of Dong-ho to the angry, prematurely wrinkled face of his older brother, Dong-ho's mother again implies that the soldiers' violence had indirect physical impacts even on those they never touched.



Structurally, it is important that this sketch of Dong-ho's early life comes so late in the narrative. By beginning with the violence and working backward to happier memories, the novel ensures that readers will be left with an image of Dong-ho as a full person rather than as a young boy shot down by state soldiers.



On the one hand, Dong-ho's mother's refusal to intervene here shows her general sense of apathy. But on the other hand, her reaction hints that she might agree with the older brother—is the middle brother to blame for not bringing Dong-ho home that day? Or worse, does Dong-ho's mother think she herself is at fault?



Consumed with doubt and regret, Dong-ho's mother thinks back to the day of her youngest son's death. Dong-ho promised to be home by six, but when the 7:00 p.m. curfew rolled around and Dong-ho still wasn't home, Dong-ho's mother and his middle brother walked the 40 minutes to the gym to retrieve him. But when they arrived, the young members of the student militia guarding the doors refused to let them in. "Only the young can be so stubborn," she thinks.

The middle brother wanted to go inside the gym to retrieve Dong-ho, but Dong-ho's mother refused: she couldn't bear the thought of losing the middle brother, too. It was getting darker, and the soldiers could come from anywhere. So, insisting that Dong-ho would be home soon, Dong-ho's mother and the middle brother walked home, tears streaming down their faces. "Why did they refuse to let me in?" Dong-ho's mother wonders now. "When they were going to die such futile deaths, what difference could it possibly have made?"

Dong-ho's mother blames herself for inviting Jeong-mi and Jeong-dae to live with them all those years ago. She had initially loved the idea that Dong-ho would have friends his age in the house, and she loved watching Dong-ho and Jeong-dae head off to school in their matching uniforms. Later, after both children disappeared, Jeong-dae's father came to Gwangju to look for them. He stayed in the annex of the hanok for a year, getting drunk and searching for his children even after it was clear they were no longer alive.

Eventually, Dong-ho's mother thinks, Jeong-dae's father must have passed away from the effort of searching for his missing children. She hates herself for renting out the annex, but then she thinks of hearing Jeong-dae and Dong-ho laughing or playing badminton, and she forgives herself. For a moment, Dong-ho's mother thinks of Jeong-mi: how pretty she was, and the sight of her walking across the courtyard "like the dreams of a previous life."

Dong-ho's mother recalls the struggle it took to keep going after Dong-ho died. For a time, even just putting food in her mouth felt exhausting. Eventually, though, she ended up getting involved with other bereaved parents, organizing for the day when Chun Doo-Hwan would next set foot in Gwangju. Dong-ho's mother felt no fear as she prepared to throw stones and protest the president—after all, what more could happen to her?

Interestingly, Dong-ho's mother is the only character in the story who was an adult at the time of the Gwangju uprising. What seemed intuitive to the other central figures thus feels like youthful folly to Dong-ho's mother. And rather than seeing the student militia's "stubborn[ness]" as courageous conviction, she sees it as childish braggadocio.



Now, Dong-ho's mother's refusal to intervene in the fight between her sons makes more sense: she was the one who prohibited the middle brother from doing more to save Dong-ho. Whereas characters like Seon-ju and the narrator work to give meaning to the lives lost in the 5:18 massacre, Dong-ho's mother sees it all as "futile." After all, Chun stayed in power for almost another decade after the protests.



The image of Dong-ho and Jeong-dae in their matching school uniforms gives further weight to the symbolism of the trackpants: the very friendship that once made Dong-ho's mother so happy ultimately led to both boy's lives being taken.



Even though Dong-ho's mother differs in her coping mechanisms from Jeong-dae and Jeong-mi's father, both find the weight of the loss and memory of their children completely all-consuming. Like Seon-ju, Dong-ho's mother knows that the line between memories and dreams (and nightmares) is porous: sometimes, it is impossible to comprehend that such tragic reality really did happen.



On the one hand, Dong-ho's mother shares Eun-sook's frustration with the idea that some bodies must continue to function while others have ceased to work. But on the other hand, Dong-ho's mother knows that continuing to fuel her body can allow her to protest against the very forces that killed her son.



When Chun Doo-Hwan actually arrived, Dong-ho's mother was among the rioters throwing stones and waving banners. Immediately, Dong-ho's mother and the others were taken to jail. When a younger protestor saw them there, he burst into tears: "Even the mothers are here, too?" he asked. "What crime have they committed?" Fueled by these words, Dong-ho's mother leapt from her chair and tears a framed picture of Chun Doo-Hwan from the wall. The glass broke, and Dong-ho's mother got a shard in her foot.

To heal her foot, Dong-ho's mother went to the hospital. While in treatment, she called her husband, instructing him to bring a banner she had made but not yet used to the following day's protest. Barely able to walk, Dong-ho's mother leaned on Dong-ho's father as she shouted at Chun Doo-hwan, "you murdered my son." After that, the mothers met often, organizing and raising funds to go to protest meetings as far away as Seoul. Even when police threw smoke grenades or tried to separate them, the mothers found their way back to each other.

The mothers vowed to continue their efforts forever, but when Dong-ho's father died, Dong-ho's mother lost steam. She both pities and envies her husband, as she wonders whether death brings reunions with lost loved ones, or only more emptiness. Now, more memories of Dong-ho come. Dong-ho's mother remembers how he nursed from her left breast, inadvertently reshaping her bent nipple. She remembers his eager crawling and unsteady walking. And she remembers how he insisted, "I don't like summer, but I like summer nights." Dong-ho's mother used to wonder if her son would be a poet.

Early in the mornings, Dong-ho's mother unwraps her son's school ID and traces Dong-ho's face with her fingers. Sometimes, Dong-ho's mother thinks back to long summertime walks with Dong-ho. Even though it was sweltering and Dong-ho was sweating, he would insist on walking in the sun—"let's go over there, where the flowers are blooming," he'd say.

EPILOGUE: THE WRITER, 2013

When the writer was nine, she and her family moved from Gwangju to a suburb of Seoul. As the writer played with her brothers or helps with dinner, she sometimes caught snippets of conversation between her parents and their friends. One time, the writer's father mentioned a former student of his in Gwangju, a young boy with a talent for creative writing. Even as a child, the writer could tell from the adults' "awkward, drawn-out silences," that something terrible had happened to this man.

This poignant moment suggests that when older people join a young person's fight, they are more intentional (showing up as "the mothers," doubling down on their actions). However, they are also more physically vulnerable (as can be seen in Dong-ho's mother's foot injury). The continued presence of banners, even when language is criminalized, once more points to the importance of language in protest.



As Dong-ho's mother joins forces with the other mothers, she finds strength from a crowd just as her son did during the 5:18 protests. And by working with the other mothers to metabolize the pain of their children's deaths, Dong-ho's mother's actions suggest that protest, too, can be a form of memory: a tangible way for her to honor her son's life.



These poetic vignettes from Dong-ho's life allow him to exist to readers 30 years after he was killed, almost as vibrantly as he once existed to his mother. The fact that Dong-ho wanted to be a poet gives new meaning to the fact that so many of those who survived him have chosen to pay tribute to him in words, honing their prose and their testimony just as an older, writerly version of Dong-ho might have, had he lived long enough.



The death of her beloved youngest son has shaped Dong-ho's mother's life more than anything else. But here, she chooses to end her narrative with a continued hope in survival and growth, letting her son's memory "bloom" on the pages just as the flowers once did in the sun.



The writer's background parallels that of author Han Kang, suggesting that the novelist has written herself into her work in this final chapter. The boy the writer's father mentions here is likely Dong-ho—a few pages ago, Dong-ho's mother mentioned her son's talent for poetry, and the writer's father, himself a writing teacher, now identifies his student as someone with a talent for creative writing.



The writer remembers her childhood home as a “typical, old-style hanok,” with its rooms arranged around a central, tiled courtyard, where roses and hollyhocks bloomed. The first winter near Seoul, the writer cannot believe how cold it is, and she finds herself hungry for the heat and flowers of Gwangju.

In the first weeks of that winter, two strange men arrived at the house in Seoul in the middle of the night. They searched the house, and though the writer’s parents never explained what was happening, she knew that her parents’ attempts to be calm concealed their panic. In the next few months, relatives warned her parents that their phone lines might be tapped. And the writer learned that soldiers had shot Dong-ho, the youngest boy in the family who’d bought the Gwangju house from them.

Two years later, the writer’s father returned home from a visit to Gwangju with a photo chapbook of the murdered and missing. After the adults looked at the chapbook, they put it on a high shelf, trying to keep it away from the children. But one evening, when her parents were busy with dinner, the writer snuck the chapbook from the shelf and looked through it. The images she saw there—of young people shot, of a woman whose face has been slashed by a bayonet—broke “something tender deep inside.”

Now, in 2013, the writer returns to Gwangju. She sees that the floor of the gym—where Dong-ho and the others once stored corpses—has been dug up. The ginkgo trees outside have been uprooted, and the only thing that remains on one of the walls is a large, framed version of the Taegukgi. The writer does her best to conjure the coffins that once filled this space. “I started too late,” she thinks. “But I’m here now.”

The writer is staying with her younger brother, who still lives in Gwangju. She has not spent time in the city in years, and she is surprised by how developed it has become, how unfamiliar all the streets feel. Even her old hanok has been torn down and replaced with a prefabricated new house. Fortunately, many of the writer’s father’s friends still live in Gwangju, and they help her find pictures of Dong-ho from his middle school records.

Though Gwangju eventually became a place of mass death, the writer remembers it before the uprising, when it was a place of warm, colorful life. The presence of hollyhocks in the writer’s old hanok effectively confirms that her family sold their Gwangju house to Dong-ho’s family (as Dong-ho’s house also had tall hollyhocks in the courtyard).



The writer’s experience of the 5:18 massacre to some extent parallels the experience readers have had. In both cases, the writer and readers feel connected to the uprising (while also being at a safe remove). Also in both cases, disorientation, graphic imagery, and fear give way to an understanding that Dong-ho, a bright young boy, was killed in a bout of political violence. More than just describing an event, then, language can also capture how an event might have felt.



The writer now begins to more explicitly parallel her own life with Dong-ho’s. Early in the novel, Dong-ho described how witnessing violence felt—as if he had been struck by a “phantom bayonet.” And in this scene, the writer describes her own connection to the massacre in Gwangju with almost exactly the same language, referencing a bayonet and describing an emotional puncture wound.



In 2013, Park Chung-hee’s daughter had recently been elected president, adding new urgency to the writer’s mission. Like Seon-ju, the narrator, and Professor Yoon, the writer wants to amplify the testimony of those who participated in the uprisings (“I’m here now,” she says, determined to bear witness). At the same time, though, the young ginkgo tree, a favorite of Dong-ho’s, has been uprooted, a reminder that no testimony can ever make up for what has been lost.



Dong-ho’s mother alluded to construction happening across Gwangju, and the writer now sees the effects of this—the home she loved and the history she fears are slowly being erased, replaced by new, less fraught landmarks.



The writer then visits the exhibit at the 5:18 Research Institute, where she studies old footage from protests and student militia gatherings. She thinks she spots Dong-ho's face in one of these videos, but because of his "utterly ordinary" features, she cannot be sure.

The writer throws herself into her work, reading every document she can get her hands on and avoiding friends entirely. As she immerses herself in the document, she begins to have nightmares. In some dreams, she imagines that soldiers are chasing her with a bayonet. In other dreams, she learns that all the 5:18 arrestees are going to be executed unless she herself puts an end to it. And in one dream, the writer finds a time machine to return to Gwangju in 1980, only to discover she has programmed the machine incorrectly.

In January of 2013, the writer attends a wedding. She feels that the bright colors and celebration is incongruous with her thoughts about Dong-ho. The research throbs in her mind: the soldiers who committed brutality "without hesitation and without regret," the way Chun Doo-hwan's government found encouragement for violence in the Cambodian government's genocide of its own people.

In one interview the writer reads, a survivor compares torture to cancer—in both cases, the memories grow and metastasize, as "life attacks itself." Whenever the narrator sees police violence, she immediately thinks of Gwangju. And with memories of Gwangju come memories of childhood fear. When she would do her homework as a little girl, lying on her stomach, the writer always wondered whether Dong-ho used to lie like that, too.

Eventually, the writer goes to the new house where her old hanok used to be. The new owner is warm at first, speaking in the classic Gwangju dialect, but when she hears the writer's Seoul speech, this woman grows cold. After some conversation, she tells the writer that the man who sold her the house works as a lecturer at a middling "cram school." The writer arranges to meet with this man, who is Dong-ho's middle brother.

The 5:18 Research Institute is a real place in Gwangju, one that author Han acknowledges as being central to her writing. "Utterly ordinary" is exactly the same phrase that Eun-sook used to describe the interrogator, reminding readers once again that "ordinary" people are capable of great bravery as well as great harm.



As these haunting dreams suggest, even the writer—despite her temporal and geographic remove—now takes on some measure of blame for Dong-ho's death (and the deaths of other protestors). The fact that the writer relies so heavily on archival documents once again serves to emphasize that language can play an important role in preserving and shaping historical narratives.



Just as mourning took over Dong-ho's mother's life, the writer now struggles with her own form of survivor's guilt. She also begins to see how crowds can provoke brutality across the globe, allowing soldiers to perform horrific acts "without regret." After all, why would a person "hesitat[e]" to engage in torture when everyone around them is doing the same thing?



This idea that trauma is cancerous echoes Seon-ju's earlier thought that memories of violence have almost radioactive half-lives. Again, the writer's own experience of youth is marked by the knowledge that somewhere a few hundred miles to the south, a young boy will never again get the basic experiences of childhood that seem so quotidian to her.



Both the new construction where the hanok used to be and the new owner's sudden coldness demonstrate the ways in which Gwangju has changed. But even as the city Dong-ho lived in is disappearing, those who love him and want to honor his memory—like his middle brother, always grieving—remain.



The middle brother is initially hesitant to share his story with the writer. But then he thinks about Dong-ho's mother, and he decides to speak the words that he knows she would want to share with the world. "Please," the middle brother implores the writer. "Write your book so that no one will ever be able to desecrate my brother's memory again." And he tells her other stories about Dong-ho, too—how they used to have toe wars, and how ticklish Dong-ho was.

The writer acknowledges that just as there were some especially aggressive soldiers, there were also some soldiers who loathed violence. Like the student militias, these were the soldiers who carried guns but refused to fire them, or pointed them up to the sky to avoid wounding others. The writer wonders if the students in the militia were true victims, or if their commitment to death was their way of avoiding victimhood—of maintaining their dignity even in the most brutal circumstances.

"Dong-ho," the writer thinks, "I need you to take my hand and guide me away from all this. Away to where the light shines through, to where the flowers bloom." For a moment, the writer imagines Dong-ho guiding her through the gravestones, the snow melting around his **trackpants**. In reality, though, the writer simply leaves a note for her brother and heads to the graveyard. She remembers the older brother writing to her about burying Dong-ho's body. The older brother had polished the skull before covering Dong-ho with the Taegukgi, knowing this task would be too painful for their mother.

At last, the writer finds Dong-ho's grave in the Mangwol-dong cemetery. She has brought a few **candles**, which she now lights. As she kneels before the grave, she realizes that her ankles are getting cold—she is standing in a snowbank. But still she stands there, staring, "mute, at that flame's wavering outline, fluttering like a bird's translucent wing."

When Dong-ho's middle brother decides to share his family's story, he does so with the knowledge that written words can protect "memory"—Dong-ho's body may have been "desecrate[d]," but his story will not be. It is especially important to the middle brother to include the details of Dong-ho's life before the violence, thus defining him outside of Chun's state brutality.



As the narrative nears its end, the writer begins to question the principle—repeated by many characters—that crowds always change behavior. Some soldiers resisted the brutal groupthink around them, for example. And while each protestor found strength from the crowd, they were also all individuals, with families and passions and quirks. Though this novel might be written about Dong-ho, a novel with as much dignity and detail could be written about any one of the protestors shot down at Gwangju.



This section blurs the lines between prose and poetry, between fiction and autobiography, and between life and death. The writer now imagines Dong-ho in the language she has attributed to his mother, calling him into physical being just as his grieving parents do. Importantly, just as Dong-ho empowers his mother to continue living and protesting, he helps the writer finish her story. It is also worth noting that despite his hesitations about the Taegukgi, Dong-ho is buried in it, perhaps a reflection of his family's faith that his activism would one day right their country's past wrongs.



At the very beginning of the novel, Dong-ho used candles to deal with death: candles masked the stench of the corpses killed in the massacre, but they also honored the victims' lives. Now, the writer does the same thing to memorialize her subject, coming to terms with his death by placing a candle by his gravestone. But in mourning and remembering the loss of young Dong-ho, the writer also gives tangible form to his soul—which "flutters" like a "bird," just as Dong-ho predicted it would.





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